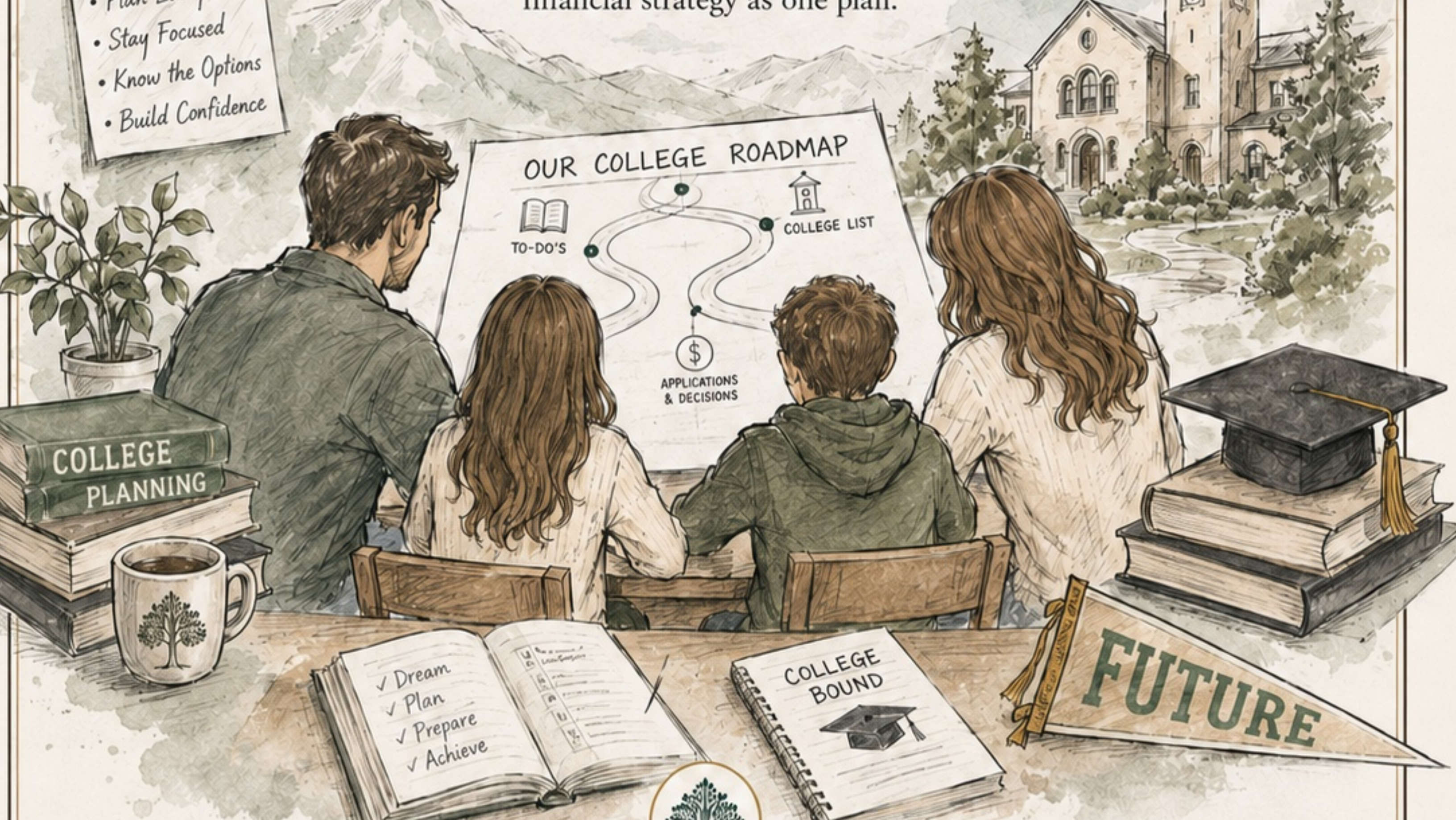
STRATEGY WEST COLLEGE PLANNING

The Complete COLLEGE PLANNING GUIDE

A parent's roadmap from eighth grade through enrollment day, covering academic, social, and financial strategy as one plan.



Strategy West College Planning

Educational Guide for Families

2026-2027 EDITION

ABOUT THIS EDITION

The Complete College Planning Guide

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We make no guarantee of any admission outcome, scholarship award, or financial aid result. No one honestly can. Every example in this guide describes one family's experience under the rules in effect at that time, and results vary with income, assets, timing, the student's record, and the policies of the specific institutions involved.

Financial aid rules, deadlines, award amounts, borrowing limits, and tax provisions change, sometimes substantially and sometimes mid-cycle. Figures in this guide are current as of publication and are collected in the reference section at the back so they can be checked in one place. Verify anything you intend to rely on at its primary source before acting. Section D of Part Seven tells you where those sources are.

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Serving families of eighth through twelfth grade students nationwide by virtual consultation, and in person in Utah.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to Use This Guide

This guide is long because the process is long. It is not meant to be read in one sitting, and for most families it should not be read front to back.

START WHERE YOUR STUDENT IS

Eighth or ninth grade. Read straight through. You have the full range of options available to you, and the sequence will make more sense than it will to anyone else.

Tenth grade. Read Parts One through Four carefully. Part Four in particular, because the financial levers are still fully open to you and this is the year almost nobody uses them.

Eleventh grade. Start with Chapter 3 to see what is still available, then go to Part Three and Part Four. Come back to Part Two afterward.

Twelfth grade. Go directly to Part Four and Part Five. Chapter 18 on award letters is the highest-value chapter in the book for you. Read Part One when the applications are in.

HOW THE PARTS FIT TOGETHER

Part One explains the shape of the whole process. Parts Two and Three cover the student's record and the college list. Part Four, the longest section, covers money. Part Five covers applications and decision season. Part Six covers readiness and the transition to campus. Part Seven holds the year-by-year roadmap and the printable worksheets, which are the pages most families end up using.

THREE CONVENTIONS

Each chapter closes with a short **What this means for your family** summary. If you are skimming, read those.

Gold **Watch out** boxes mark the places where families most often lose money or options. There are not many of them, and each one is there for a reason.

Every dollar figure, deadline, and program limit lives in the reference section at the back rather than in the body, so that it can be updated in one place each year. Check the date on that section before relying on any number in it.

CONTENTS

What Is Inside

The worksheets in Section B of Part Seven are designed to be printed. So are the six roadmap pages in Section A. If you print nothing else from this guide, print those.

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PART ONE

How the Process Actually Works

Before any of the individual decisions make sense, it helps to see the shape of the whole thing. This part is short on purpose. It is the map you will hold in your head while you read the rest.

IN THIS PART

CHAPTER ONE

Why Good Families Get Blindsided

The families who end up with the fewest options are almost never the ones who did not care. They are the ones who cared at the wrong time.

It is early April of senior year. Three letters are on the kitchen table. The student got into all three schools, which is genuinely good news, and the family has spent the last hour discovering that they cannot comfortably afford any of them.

They are not careless people. They saved. They went to the college nights. They pushed on grades and drove to the tournaments and proofread the essays. Somewhere along the way they assumed that if they did the obviously responsible things, the money part would sort itself out or at least announce itself in time to be dealt with.

It did announce itself. It announced itself in April, which is roughly three years after the point at which anything could have been done about it.

We have sat with a version of this family many times. What follows is not a scare tactic and it is not an argument that college is unaffordable. It is an explanation of why smart, engaged, financially careful people routinely get surprised by a process they were paying attention to the entire time.

Four Reasons This Keeps Happening

THE PROCESS IS SEQUENTIAL, AND THE EARLY STEPS DO NOT FEEL URGENT

Almost every consequential decision in college planning is made before it feels consequential. The course a ninth grader takes in math determines what is available to them as a junior. The activity a tenth grader sticks with becomes the only thing on the application with four years behind it. The income a family earns during a student's sophomore year is the income a college will use to calculate aid for freshman year.

None of those moments come with an alarm attached. They feel like ordinary Tuesdays. The alarm goes off years later, at which point it is reporting on decisions rather than prompting them.

IT IS THREE PROCESSES, NOT ONE, AND THEY ARE USUALLY HANDLED SEPARATELY

Getting admitted is one problem. Presenting a student compellingly is a second. Paying for it is a third. Most families work these as separate tracks, often with different people, and frequently with a gap of a year or more between when they start the first and when they start the third.

The trouble is that the three are not independent. A college list built without financial input is a list that may be unaffordable no matter how the admissions results come back. That is Chapter 2, and it is the central idea of this guide.

NOBODY IS ASSIGNED TO OWN IT

This one deserves care, because it is easy to state unfairly. High school counselors are, in our experience, dedicated and capable people. They are also carrying caseloads that in many districts run to several hundred students, alongside scheduling, testing coordination, and crisis response. Under those conditions, the realistic service any single family receives is a handful of conversations concentrated in junior and senior year.

That is not a failure on anyone's part. It is arithmetic. But it means that if nobody in your household is holding the four-year picture, then nobody is holding it.

THE INFORMATION IS PUBLIC, SCATTERED, AND FREQUENTLY OUT OF DATE

Everything a family needs to know is technically available. It is also spread across federal websites, individual college financial aid pages, forums, and a large volume of content written before the rules changed.

That last point matters more than it sounds. The federal financial aid system was substantially rewritten beginning with the 2024-25 award year. A great deal of advice still circulating online, including advice that reads as authoritative, describes a system that no longer exists. Families doing careful research sometimes arrive at confident conclusions that were accurate three years ago.

WATCH OUT

If you are reading college funding advice that refers to your family's "EFC" or "Expected Family Contribution," you are reading about the previous system. The current federal figure is the Student Aid Index, and it is calculated differently. This is a fast way to check whether a source has been updated.

This Is a Coordination Problem, Not a Crisis

We want to be careful here, because there is an entire genre of college funding marketing built on frightening parents, and we have no interest in joining it.

The situation is this. College is expensive, the aid system is more responsive to planning than most families realize, and the planning has to happen earlier than feels natural. That is a real problem with a reasonable solution. It is not an emergency, and there is no version of this where a family who starts thoughtfully in tenth grade ends up in trouble.

> *Almost everything that goes wrong in this process goes wrong quietly, and long before anyone notices.*

What This Guide Is For

The rest of this document is organized around a simple premise: if you can see the whole sequence in advance, you can make each decision on time rather than in retrospect.

Part One gives you the framework. Parts Two and Three cover the student's academic record, personal development, and the college list. Part Four, the longest section, covers money in detail. Part Five walks through applications and decision season. Part Six covers enrollment and the transition to campus. Part Seven contains the year-by-year roadmap and the worksheets, which are the pages most families end up printing.

If your student is already a junior or senior, do not read this front to back. Start with Part Four, then Part Five, then come back. The chronological reading is for families who still have time to use it.

CHAPTER TWO

The Three Pillars

Academic, social, and financial. Most families work on one of them at a time. The outcomes change when a family works on all three as one thing.

Every family we work with is dealing with the same three questions, whether or not they have named them. What does the student's record say? Who is the student, beyond the record? And what will this actually cost us?

We call these the three pillars, and we treat them as a single strategy rather than three projects. Here is what each one covers and, more importantly, how each one moves the other two.

Pillar One: Academic Strategy

The academic record is the foundation of both admission and money. It covers course selection and rigor, the GPA trajectory across four years, standardized testing strategy, and the way a transcript reads to someone who evaluates several thousand of them a year.

The part families most often miss is the money half. Test-optional admission policies have led a lot of parents to conclude that scores no longer matter anywhere. For admission at many schools, that is largely true. For money it is less settled. A minority of institutions still tie an automatic merit award or honors college consideration to a score, so at some schools a strong result opens a door that would otherwise stay shut. This is the exception rather than the pattern, but it is worth knowing which schools on your list work that way before deciding to skip the test.

Pillar Two: Social Strategy

Colleges are not admitting transcripts. They are admitting people, and they are trying to build a class. Social strategy covers activities and the depth of involvement in them, leadership understood as demonstrated responsibility rather than a title, summers, the essay, recommendation letters, and demonstrated interest.

The common failure here is a student who has done eleven things and can speak meaningfully about none of them. The student who has done three things for four years, one of which they started themselves, reads as a person. That difference is visible on paper and it is not something that can be assembled in the fall of senior year.

Pillar Three: Financial Strategy

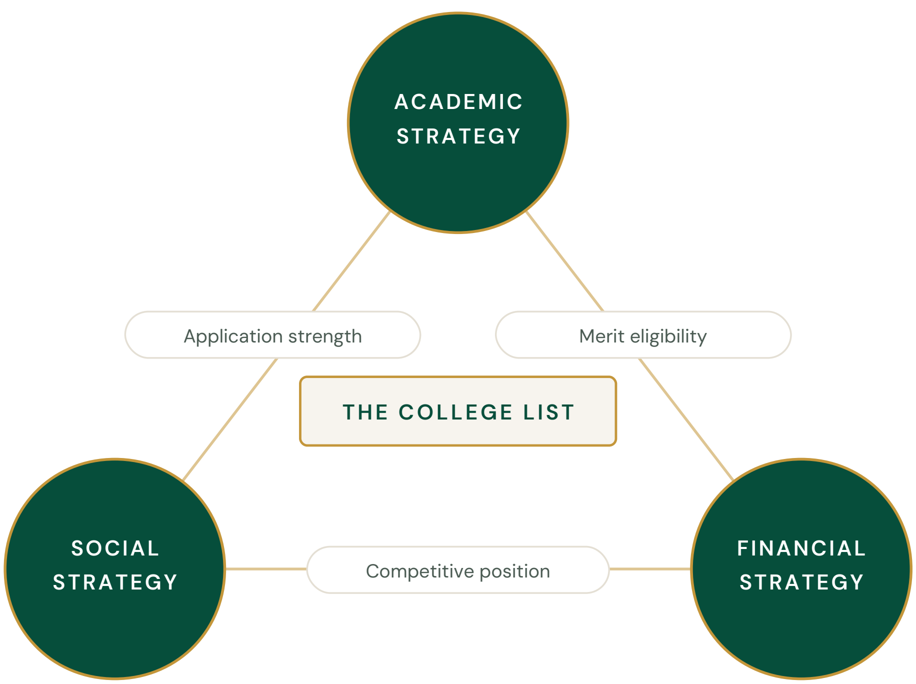
This pillar covers how aid is actually calculated, the FAFSA and the CSS Profile, the difference between need-based and merit aid, net price, positioning before you file, borrowing, and the reading and appealing of award letters.

It is the pillar with the shortest deadlines and the most misinformation around it, and it is the one families most often postpone. It is also the only one where the value of expert help is directly measurable in dollars.

The Part That Matters: They Are Not Independent

If you take one idea from this guide, take this one. The three pillars do not sit side by side. They feed each other, and the place where all three converge is the college list.

HOW THE THREE PILLARS INTERLOCK



The list is where the three pillars meet. A list built from only one of them tends to fail on the other two.

Work around the triangle and the dependencies become concrete.

Academic to financial. Where a student sits relative to a school's applicant pool is what drives merit money. The same student, with the same transcript, can be an ordinary admit at one school and a recruited-with-money admit at another of comparable quality. The academic profile is not just an admissions asset. It is a pricing asset.

Social to academic. A strong record with no coherent story behind it is a weaker application than the same record attached to a student an admissions reader can picture. This is what closes the gap at selective schools where every applicant has the grades.

Financial to the list. Which schools belong on a list at all depends on how each one awards aid. Two institutions with identical published prices can produce offers $25,000 apart, because one meets a high share of demonstrated need and the other does not, or because one uses merit aggressively to attract students and the other does not need to. A family that does not know which is which is choosing blind.

> WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY
>
> - Do not sequence these. Working the academic pillar for two years and then starting on money is the single most common structural mistake we see.
> - When you build the college list, bring all three pillars to it at once. The list is the decision that carries the most financial weight, and it is usually made with the least financial information.
> - If you are currently working with someone on admissions and separately with someone on finances, make sure one of them is looking at the other's work.

CHAPTER THREE

What Actually Changes When You Start Early

Every guide tells you to start early. Very few will tell you exactly what you lose by waiting, or what remains available if you already have.

"Start early" is advice that has been repeated into meaninglessness. It is also true, and the honest way to make it useful is to be specific about which levers close and when.

What follows is our own assessment, based on the families we work with, of what is realistically available depending on where a student is when the family begins. Read it as a diagnostic rather than a verdict.

WHICH LEVERS ARE STILL AVAILABLE TO YOU

LEVER	ENTERING 9TH	10TH GRADE	JUNIOR FALL	SENIOR FALL
Course rigor and sequence	Fully open	Mostly open	Narrow	Closed
GPA trajectory	Fully open	Mostly open	Narrow	Closed
Testing timeline and preparation	Fully open	Fully open	Compressed	Narrow
Depth of activity involvement	Fully open	Mostly open	Narrow	Closed
Planning around the scored income year	Fully open	Fully open	Narrow	Closed
Asset positioning before filing	Fully open	Fully open	Mostly open	Narrow
Building the list around financial fit	Fully open	Fully open	Fully open	Fully open
Net price research before applying	Fully open	Fully open	Fully open	Fully open
Reading, comparing, and appealing awards	Fully open	Fully open	Fully open	Fully open

Fully open Full range of action **Mostly open** Meaningful action possible **Narrow** Limited but real **Closed** Largely set

Read the Bottom Three Rows First

If your student is a junior or a senior, the top of that table is not comfortable reading. Read the bottom three rows instead, because they are the point.

Building a college list around financial fit, researching net price before applying rather than after, and reading and appealing award letters competently are available to every family at every stage. They also happen to be three of the highest-value activities in the entire process, and they are the three that families skip most often.

We have worked with families who came to us in October of senior year and still saved meaningful money, because the list had not been finalized and nobody had yet looked at how each school on it actually awards aid. Late is worse than early. Late is not the same as too late.

The One That Closes Quietly

The row worth staring at is the one about the scored income year, because it is the only lever on the list that closes without anyone noticing.

Financial aid calculations use income from two years before the school year in question. A student entering college in the fall of 2028 will have their first year of aid calculated on the family's 2026 income. For a family with a student currently in ninth grade, that year has not started yet. For a family with a junior, it has already ended.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Count backward right now. Take the fall your student will enroll, subtract two, and you have the calendar year that will determine their first year of aid. If that year has not happened yet, you have a planning opportunity that most families never know they had. If it has already closed, your attention belongs on assets, on the college list, and on the years after freshman year, which are still scored separately.

What Early Actually Buys

It is worth naming what a family gets out of starting in eighth or ninth grade, because it is not what most people assume. It is not a more impressive student. It is optionality.

A family who starts early gets to choose the course sequence rather than inherit it. They get to test twice with room for a third attempt instead of once with no margin. They get to let a student abandon an activity that is not working in tenth grade and still have three years of depth in whatever replaces it. They get to make a financial decision in a year that has not been scored yet. And when the offers arrive, they get to compare them from a position of having built the list deliberately rather than hopefully.

> *None of that requires doing more. It requires doing the same things in a different order.*

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Locate your student's row honestly. Work the levers that are open and stop spending energy on the ones that are not.
- Calculate the scored income year today. It takes ten seconds and it determines whether an entire category of planning is available to you.
- If you have a younger sibling, note that their scored years are different and mostly still ahead of you. Families frequently apply what they learned with the first student to the second and do considerably better.

WHERE FAMILIES USUALLY START

A short conversation, before you read the other ninety pages.

Most of this guide is self-serviceable, and we would rather you use it that way. The table on the previous page is the exception, because it is easier to read about your own family with someone who does this daily. A consultation will tell you which levers are genuinely open to you and what the scored income year means in your case. Sometimes the answer is that you do not need us, and we will say so.

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PART TWO

Building the Student's Profile

Everything a college will eventually evaluate is built during four ordinary years of high school. This part covers what actually goes into that record, and what a reader on the other end is looking for when they open it.

IN THIS PART

CHAPTER FOUR

Course Selection and Rigor

The schedule your student registers for in February is the single most consequential academic decision of the year, and it is usually made in about fifteen minutes.

Course registration tends to happen in a hurry. A form comes home, a counselor has twenty minutes, a student picks what their friends picked or what fits around the schedule, and the family signs it. Four of those fifteen-minute decisions become the transcript.

It is worth slowing that down, because course selection is where the academic pillar is actually built, and because the constraint most families do not see is sequencing.

What "Most Rigorous" Actually Means

Most high schools send colleges a document describing the school itself: what courses it offers, how many students take them, how the GPA is calculated. Alongside the transcript, a counselor typically indicates how demanding the student's schedule was relative to what was available at that school.

That last phrase is the one that matters. Your student is not being measured against a national standard of rigor. They are being measured against their own high school's course catalog. A student at a school offering six advanced courses who takes five of them is in a stronger position than a student at a school offering twenty-five who takes seven.

This is genuinely good news for families at smaller or less resourced high schools, and it is a useful corrective for families who assume their student needs to match some imagined national arms race. Take the hardest reasonable path available to you. That is the whole instruction.

The Options, and What Each One Is Good For

ADVANCED COURSEWORK COMPARED

TYPE	WHAT IT IS	WHAT TO KNOW
Honors	An accelerated version of a standard course, defined by your high school.	Usually the entry point to a rigorous track. Rarely carries college credit. Standards vary widely between schools.
Advanced Placement	A national curriculum with an exam scored 1 to 5 each May.	Widely recognized. Credit awarded at the receiving college's discretion, and the required score varies by school and by subject.
International Baccalaureate	A structured multi-year program, offered as individual courses or a full diploma.	Well regarded and demanding. The full diploma is a significant commitment and should be entered deliberately, not drifted into.
Concurrent or dual enrollment	Actual college courses taken during high school, often taught at the high school.	Produces a real college transcript. Credit generally transfers well within the same state system and less predictably outside it.

Since we are based in Utah, concurrent enrollment deserves a specific mention. Utah students can earn credit from state institutions, including the University of Utah, while still in high school and at a fraction of standard tuition. For a family paying attention, that combination of rigor on the transcript and credit on the ledger is one of the better values available anywhere in the country.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Credit earned in high school does not transfer uniformly. The University of Utah, Brigham Young University, and an out-of-state private college may each treat the same Advanced Placement score or the same concurrent enrollment course differently, and some programs cap how much outside credit they will accept toward a major. Check the published policy at each school on your student's list rather than assuming. Credits that do transfer can shorten time to degree, which is one of the largest available savings in the entire process.

Sequencing Is the Constraint Nobody Sees

Advanced courses sit at the end of chains. A student cannot take a particular course as a senior without having taken its prerequisite as a junior, and so on backward to ninth grade. Mathematics and world languages are the two chains that most often close off options quietly.

The practical consequence is that a ninth grade placement decision can determine whether a specific advanced course is available three years later. Nobody presents it that way at the time. It is presented as a reasonable choice between two math classes.

The fix is not complicated. Once a year, sit down with the school's course catalog and map the sequence forward to twelfth grade. It takes an hour and it surfaces every chain in the building.

The B in the Hard Class

Every family eventually asks a version of this question. Is an A in the regular class better than a B in the advanced one?

The honest answer is that a reader is looking at both the grade and the context, and that a strong record in a demanding schedule generally reads better than a flawless record in an undemanding one. But that answer comes with a limit, and the limit is real. A student who is genuinely overmatched, who is sleeping five hours a night and whose grades are sliding across every subject, is not building a stronger application. They are building a weaker one, and paying for it in ways that have nothing to do with college.

> *Take the hardest schedule your student can carry well. The operative word is well.*

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Map the course sequence to twelfth grade once a year, before registration rather than after.
- Measure rigor against your own school's catalog, not against a national standard or a neighbor's student.
- Treat concurrent enrollment as both an academic and a financial decision, and verify credit transfer policy at the schools your student is actually considering.
- Adjust the load in the first month if it is clearly too heavy. A schedule change in September is a small event. A collapsed semester is not.

CHAPTER FIVE

GPA, and What It Really Signals

Families track one number. Colleges look at several, and they usually calculate their own.

The grade point average on a report card feels like a fact. It is closer to an opinion, and it is one that different institutions form differently.

Weighted, Unweighted, and Recalculated

An unweighted average treats every course on the same four point scale. A weighted average adds value for advanced coursework, which is why a student can carry an average above 4.0. High schools weight differently, and some do not weight at all.

Because of that inconsistency, many colleges recalculate. A common approach strips out non-academic courses, sometimes ignores ninth grade, and applies the institution's own weighting. The number a family has been watching for three years may not be the number that gets used.

There is one practical takeaway from this. Pay attention to the unweighted average, not only the weighted one. Where published scholarship criteria exist, they are frequently stated in unweighted terms, and a family tracking only the weighted figure can misjudge where their student stands against a published threshold.

Trajectory Reads Louder Than Any Single Term

A reader looking at four years of grades is reading a story, not calculating an average. A student who started at a 3.1 and finished at a 3.9 is telling a story about growth and capacity. A student who started at a 3.9 and finished at a 3.4 is telling a different one, and the second student may have the higher cumulative average.

This is the most encouraging fact in the academic pillar, and we point it out to families constantly. A difficult freshman year is recoverable. Junior year carries more weight than freshman year at essentially every institution, and a clear upward line is one of the more persuasive things a transcript can show.

When a Year Goes Badly

Sometimes a semester falls apart, and often for reasons that have nothing to do with effort. Illness, a death in the family, a move, a mental health crisis, a teacher who was a genuinely poor fit.

Two things are worth knowing. First, applications include a place to provide context, and a brief factual explanation from a counselor is more effective than either silence or a lengthy defense. Second, the response that actually matters is the following year. Context explains a dip. Recovery resolves it.

> **WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY**
>
> - Know both averages. Ask the school how your student's weighted GPA is calculated, because the method is not standard.
> - Watch the direction as closely as the number. An improving line is an asset in its own right.
> - If something went wrong, document it factually at the time and focus the energy on the next two semesters.

CHAPTER SIX

Testing in a Test-Optional World

The question is no longer whether your student has to test. It is whether testing is worth it for your student, at the schools on your student's list.

Testing policy has moved a great deal in recent years, and it is still moving. Some institutions have returned to requiring scores, many remain optional, and a smaller group does not consider them at all. Any blanket statement about standardized testing is going to be wrong somewhere.

So this chapter does not tell you to test. It gives you a way to decide.

Start With the List, Not the Test

The decision is downstream of where your student is applying. Before committing to a testing plan, check three things at each school under consideration: whether scores are required, recommended, optional, or not reviewed; what the middle range of admitted students looked like most recently; and whether any published scholarship or honors program at that school references a score.

That third item is the one families skip. It is a minority of schools, and we do not want to overstate it. But at institutions that publish automatic award criteria, a score can be part of the qualification, and a student who never tested simply is not in the running for that particular award. It is a twenty-minute check per school and it occasionally changes the math.

Which Test, and When

The two exams differ in pacing, structure, and emphasis, and students frequently perform better on one than the other for reasons that have little to do with overall ability. Both are accepted everywhere scores are accepted, and no institution prefers one. Take a full practice version of each under timed conditions, compare the results, and commit to whichever one fits.

Both exams have been revised recently, including changes to format, length, and delivery. Because these details change, we have kept the current specifics in the reference section at the back rather than in this chapter.

A WORKABLE TESTING TIMELINE

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENS
Sophomore fall	Take the PSAT if your school offers it. Treat it as a diagnostic with no stakes attached.
Sophomore spring	Sit a full practice SAT and a full practice ACT under timed conditions. Decide which test to pursue.
Junior fall	The PSAT this year is the one that determines National Merit consideration. Begin structured preparation.
Junior winter or spring	First official attempt, after real preparation rather than as a trial run.
Summer before senior year	Second attempt. This is the most underused window in the calendar, because there is no coursework competing for the student's attention.
Senior fall	A third attempt if it is worth it, timed to land before application deadlines.

Test dates, registration deadlines, and score release timing change annually. Confirm current dates before building your student's plan.

Two mechanics are worth understanding before you build a plan. Many institutions superscore, combining a student's best section results across multiple sittings, which makes retaking considerably more attractive than families assume. And most schools allow students to choose which scores to send. Policies differ, so verify at each school, but in general a disappointing attempt does not have to follow a student anywhere.

What Actually Moves a Score

There is a large industry built on the idea that these exams can be outmaneuvered. In our experience the thing that moves scores is far less interesting than that. It is volume of practice under real timing conditions, review of every missed question until the underlying gap is understood rather than merely noted, and enough weeks to let that cycle repeat.

Which means the constraint is almost always calendar, not aptitude. A student who begins in the fall of junior year has room for that cycle to run several times. A student who begins in September of senior year does not, regardless of how capable they are or how much is spent.

A FAMILY WE WORKED WITH

A 4.0 student, stuck at 1250

A student came to us with a 4.0 unweighted average and a testing problem. Two attempts at the SAT had produced scores around 1250, which is a good result by any ordinary measure and was nonetheless out of step with the rest of the application. The schools the family had in mind were ones where that gap would be noticed.

Through our program the student had unlimited access to test preparation, and they used it. Not once, and not as a weekend course. They worked through it repeatedly across months. On the third official attempt the score came back at 1520.

FIRST TWO ATTEMPTS	THIRD ATTEMPT	IMPROVEMENT
1250	1520	+270
Composite SAT	After sustained preparation	Across roughly six months

The score changed which schools were realistic. It also changed the conversation about money, because a student positioned at the top of an applicant pool is a student an institution has reason to compete for.

This is one student's outcome, and an unusually strong one. Score improvement varies enormously by student, by starting point, and by how much preparation actually gets done. Most students who prepare seriously improve; very few improve by this much. Nothing here is a projection of what any other student should expect, and no preparation program can promise a particular result.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Decide school by school, not in the abstract. Check requirement, middle range, and any published award criteria at each institution on the list.
- Choose the test with a timed practice comparison rather than a guess.
- Protect the summer before senior year. It is the best preparation window in the calendar and almost nobody uses it.
- If your student is going to test, start early enough that the practice cycle can actually repeat. Time is the input that matters most.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Depth Beats Breadth

The activity list is the part of the application families most often over-engineer, and it is the part where doing less usually works better.

A common instinct is to treat the activities section as a container to be filled. Ten slots, ten entries, and a scramble in junior year to find things to put in the empty ones.

That instinct is understandable and it produces weak applications. A list of eleven shallow involvements reads as a student who joined things. A list of three sustained ones, with growth visible inside them, reads as a person.

What Depth Looks Like on Paper

Depth is legible in three ways. Duration, which is simply how many years a student stayed. Progression, meaning the role changed over time from participant toward something more responsible. And specificity, meaning the student can describe what they actually did rather than what the organization does.

A student who joined the robotics team as a freshman, spent two years doing unglamorous work, ran the build subteam as a junior, and mentored the incoming freshmen as a senior has produced something no amount of senior-year activity can replicate. The four-year commitment is the evidence, and it cannot be manufactured late.

Leadership Is Not a Title

Families often chase officer positions, and the positions are fine. But what a reader is looking for is evidence that other people relied on this student and that the student handled it.

A student who reorganized how their team handles equipment, trained the younger players, or kept a struggling club alive through a bad year has demonstrated more than a student who won an uncontested election for treasurer. Both may appear on an application. Only one of them has something to write about.

The Thing They Started Themselves

If a student has one genuine interest, the highest-return move in this entire pillar is to build something around it that did not exist before. A tutoring program, a small repair service, a recurring community event, a body of creative work, a research project pursued with a teacher's guidance.

This is not about impressiveness. A modest project that a student actually ran and can speak about honestly is worth more than an elaborate one that a parent organized. Readers can tell the difference, and students give themselves away in interviews and essays when the work was not really theirs.

The Four Summers

Summers are unstructured time, which means they are where a student's actual priorities become visible. They are also where families spend money unnecessarily.

We want to say something plainly here, because it saves families real money. An expensive summer program at a prestigious institution is not, by itself, a meaningful credential. Many of these programs admit anyone who can pay, and experienced readers know which ones. A student who worked forty hours a week at a restaurant, contributed to the household, and can describe what they learned about responsibility and people is frequently the stronger applicant.

Good summers generally do one of four things: advance a genuine interest, build a skill, produce something, or provide real work experience. A program that does one of those may be worth its price. A program that mostly provides a photograph on a famous campus is not.

> *Colleges are not evaluating whether a summer looked expensive. They are evaluating what a student did with fourteen unsupervised weeks.*

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Aim for two or three sustained commitments rather than a full list. Quality of involvement beats quantity every time.
- Let a student quit something in ninth or tenth grade if it is not right. The earlier they land on the thing that fits, the more years of depth they accumulate.
- Look for growing responsibility rather than titles, and help your student notice their own when it happens.
- Evaluate summer programs on what the student will produce or learn, not on whose campus it takes place.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Student's Story

Everything in the application is evidence. The story is what the evidence adds up to, and somebody has to make sure it adds up to something.

An application arrives as a pile of parts. A transcript, a list of activities, an essay, two or three letters, sometimes a score. A reader assembles those parts into an impression of a person, and they do it quickly.

The families who do this well are not the ones who invent a narrative in senior year. They are the ones who notice, somewhere around junior year, that a narrative has already formed and that the job is to communicate it clearly.

Finding the Through-Line

Sit down with your student and ask what they have actually spent their time on for four years. Not what they wish they had done. What the calendar says.

Usually a pattern is visible. A student who worked in a kitchen, took every chemistry course available, and taught themselves to bake seriously has a through-line whether or not anyone has named it. It does not need to point at a career and it does not need to be unusual. It needs to be true.

The Essay

The main essay is not a summary of accomplishments, and it is not the place to restate the activity list in paragraph form. It is a short piece of writing whose only real job is to make a stranger feel like they have met someone.

The essays that work are usually small. A specific afternoon, a particular conversation, one thing that went wrong. The essays that do not work are usually large: a summary of a whole experience, a lesson stated directly, an attempt to sound older than the writer is.

Two failure modes are worth naming because they are so common. The first is the essay that has been polished by adults until the student's voice is gone. Readers notice, and it costs more than the awkwardness it fixed. The second is the essay about an experience the student did not really have, which tends to collapse under any specific question.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> There is a version of parental help that makes an essay worse. If your student's draft sounds like your student, resist the urge to make it sound impressive. Ask questions instead. What did that actually feel like? What did you say next? The specifics your student adds in response are almost always better than anything an adult would have written for them.

Recommendation Letters

The best letter comes from a teacher who knows your student rather than a teacher who gave your student an A. Those are sometimes the same person and frequently not. Ask in the spring of junior year, before the fall crush. Choose teachers from junior year in core academic subjects, and where possible pick one who saw the student struggle with something and work through it. Give each recommender a short written summary of what the student did in their class and what they are applying for. And ask in person when you can.

Demonstrated Interest, Honestly

Some institutions track whether an applicant has engaged with them by opening emails, visiting, attending sessions, or interviewing. Others do not consider it at all, and the most selective institutions are generally in the second group. Where it is tracked, it functions as a tiebreaker among comparable applicants rather than as a lever that overcomes a weak application. Open the emails, take the interview when it is offered, visit the schools you can reasonably reach, and do not build a strategy around it.

Visits and Interviews

A campus visit is worth more than most families extract from it. Go while school is in session, sit in the student union rather than only walking the tour route, and talk to students who are not employed by the admissions office. Interviews, where offered, are usually conversational rather than evaluative in any severe sense, and the preparation that helps is not rehearsal. It is a student who can talk specifically about two or three things they have done and who has two real questions about the school.

SEE ALSO CHAPTER 10, WHAT FIT MEANS AND HOW TO RESEARCH IT

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Name the through-line in junior year. It already exists; the work is noticing it, not building it.
- Ask for recommendation letters in the spring of junior year, with a written summary attached.
- Protect your student's voice in the essay. Ask questions rather than making edits.
- Treat demonstrated interest as a tiebreaker at some schools and as nothing at others. Verify which is which before spending time on it.

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PART THREE

Choosing Where to Apply

The college list is the highest-leverage decision in this entire process, and it is usually the one made with the least information. This part is about making it deliberately.

IN THIS PART

CHAPTER NINE

Careers and Majors Before Colleges

Most families build a college list and then figure out the major. Doing it in the other order is cheaper, and it is not much harder.

A seventeen year old is not supposed to know what they want to do with their life. Nobody is asking them to. But there is a large difference between certainty and direction, and the process rewards direction quite a lot.

What Getting This Wrong Actually Costs

The cost of arriving on campus with no sense of direction is not abstract. It shows up as extra semesters.

STUDENTS WHO FINISH A BACHELOR'S DEGREE IN FOUR YEARS	ADDED COST OF A FIFTH YEAR
49%	~28%
First-time, full-time students at four-year institutions	Against a four-year in-state public total

Sources: U.S. Department of Education, National Center for Education Statistics; College Board, Trends in College Pricing. Figures are national averages and vary considerably by institution.

Not every extra semester traces back to a change of direction. But a great many do. A student who switches from one field to an unrelated one after two years is frequently starting a new prerequisite chain from the beginning, and prerequisite chains do not compress. The result is another year of tuition, another year of housing, and a year of earnings that never happens.

Put in those terms, an honest afternoon of career exploration in tenth grade is one of the highest-return activities in this guide.

Direction, Not Certainty

What a student actually needs before building a college list is a general area of study. Health sciences. Engineering and applied sciences. Business and finance. Education. The arts. Something in the humanities and social sciences. That level of resolution is enough to evaluate whether a school is a serious place to study the thing.

We say this to students directly: you are not signing anything. Most people change their minds, and changing from one field into a neighboring one usually costs very little. What is expensive is having no direction at all for two years, and then discovering one.

How to Actually Narrow It Down

Interest inventories have their place, but they tend to produce lists rather than conviction. The things that move students are more concrete.

- Conversations with adults who do the work. Twenty minutes with someone in the field beats an hour of reading about it, and most people say yes when a teenager asks.
- Actual exposure. A shadow day, a summer job adjacent to the field, a volunteer role in the setting.
- Coursework, which is the cheapest test available. A student who thinks they want engineering should take physics before deciding.
- Reading job listings rather than program brochures. Listings describe what the work is. Brochures describe what the school is selling.

A useful exercise, and one we run with families: have the student name ten to fifteen careers that hold any interest, then work backward to the two to four fields of study that lead there. The overlap is usually clarifying, and the list of ten is easier for a sixteen year old to produce than the list of one.

Two Things Families Learn Too Late

SOME PROGRAMS ARE ENTERED AT ADMISSION, NOT LATER

This one causes real damage. At many institutions, certain programs admit directly. Nursing, engineering, business, architecture, and some performance and design programs frequently work this way. A student admitted to the university generally, intending to transfer into the program as a sophomore, may find that internal transfer is competitive, capped, or effectively closed.

WATCH OUT

If your student has any serious interest in a direct-admit field, check the policy at every school on the list before applying, not after. The question to ask is specific: can a student who applies undeclared later transfer into this program, and what share of students who attempt that transfer succeed? Some admissions offices will answer plainly. The reluctance of the ones that will not is itself informative.

THE FIELD AFFECTS WHAT BORROWING IS REASONABLE

We are cautious about reducing education to a return calculation, and we are not going to tell a student what to study. But starting salaries differ substantially by field, and that difference is relevant to one specific question: how much debt is sensible.

The same $60,000 of borrowing lands very differently depending on what follows graduation. That is not an argument against any field. It is an argument for making the borrowing decision and the field decision in the same conversation instead of four years apart.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Aim for a general area of study by the end of sophomore year. Not a career, not a major, an area.
- Have your student name ten to fifteen careers of interest, then work backward to two to four fields.
- Check direct-admit policies at every school on the list if a competitive program is in play.
- Discuss field and borrowing capacity together rather than treating them as separate topics.

CHAPTER TEN

What Fit Means, and How to Research It

Fit is one of the most overused words in college admissions and one of the least defined. Here is a definition you can actually apply.

A school fits a student when three separate things are true at once. The student can do the work and be challenged rather than buried. The student can live there for four years and be reasonably happy. And the family can pay for it without a decision they will regret.

Miss on any one of those and the other two rarely compensate.

Academic Fit

The first question is where the student sits relative to the institution's admitted class. A student near the top of a school's range will find the work manageable and will be visible to faculty and to the scholarship committee. A student well below it may be admitted and then spend four years underwater.

The second question is whether the school is a serious place to study the thing your student wants to study. Every university has a website that makes every department look excellent. Look instead at how many faculty are actually in the department, what courses ran last year rather than what appears in the catalog, and where recent graduates of that specific program went.

The third is the teaching model: class sizes in the first two years, who teaches the introductory courses, how advising works, and whether undergraduates get real access to research or internships. Two schools with identical reputations can differ enormously here.

Social Fit

This is the dimension students care most about and articulate least well. The useful prompts are concrete: how large, how urban, how far from home, and what people actually do on a Saturday.

Distance deserves specific thought. A student who will want to come home on occasional weekends needs a school within a few hours; a student who wants genuine independence may want more. Both are legitimate, and the conversation goes better in eleventh grade than in August of freshman year.

So does the residential question. Where most students live on campus, the social life is on campus. At a heavily commuter school, a student wanting an immersive experience may struggle to find one. Neither model is better. They are different products.

Financial Fit

A school is a financial fit when the realistic net price, not the published price, is a number your family can pay across four years without borrowing beyond what is sensible.

That number is knowable before you apply, and Part Four is devoted to finding it. The point here is only that financial fit belongs in the list conversation from the start rather than arriving in April as a surprise.

SEE ALSO CHAPTER 15, STICKER PRICE, COST OF ATTENDANCE, NET PRICE, TRUE COST

Why Rankings Are a Poor Substitute

Rankings are not useless. They are a rough proxy for institutional resources and reputation, and reputation does matter in some fields.

But they measure the institution, not the experience of a particular student inside it, and they weight things a family may not care about at all. More to the point, they are national averages applied to a decision that is entirely individual. The eleventh-ranked school may be substantially better for your student than the fourth, and it may cost $20,000 a year less because your student sits higher in its pool.

> *Use rankings to discover schools you had not heard of. Do not use them to order the ones you have.*

Where the Real Information Is

Almost everything worth knowing about a school is published somewhere other than its viewbook.

SOURCES WORTH YOUR TIME

SOURCE	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
The school's Common Data Set	Admission rates, test score ranges, what factors the school says it weighs, and how much aid it awards. Most institutions publish it. Search the school name plus the term.
The net price calculator	An estimate of what your family specifically would pay. Every school that receives federal aid is required to host one.
Federal outcomes data	Graduation rates, retention, and post-enrollment earnings by field of study, published by the U.S. Department of Education.
The department's own pages	Faculty roster, courses actually offered, requirements, and where graduates went.
Current students	What no publication will tell you. The ones not employed by the admissions office are the ones to find.

Making a Campus Visit Count

Most families take the tour, buy the sweatshirt, and leave with an impression formed almost entirely by the weather and the guide's personality. A visit can do considerably more than that.

Go while classes are in session. Walk away from the tour route. Eat in a dining hall. Sit somewhere central for twenty minutes and watch. Read the flyers on the bulletin boards, which describe the actual campus rather than the marketed one. And find two or three students who are not working for the admissions office.

A handful of questions are worth asking every time:

- What do people do here on a Saturday?
- What is the thing you wish you had known before you came?
- Who taught your first-year courses, and how big were they?
- How easy is it to get the classes you need to graduate on time?
- How do students here find internships, and who helps with that?
- What kind of student is not happy here?

The last one is the most useful question in the set, and the honesty of the answer tells you a great deal on its own. There is a printable version of these questions, along with a separate set for the financial aid office, in Part Seven.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Score every school on all three dimensions before it goes on the list, not after an acceptance arrives.
- Pull the Common Data Set and run the net price calculator for any school your student is serious about.
- Visit while school is in session, and spend as much time off the tour route as on it.
- Ask what kind of student is not happy there. Then listen to how the answer is delivered.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Building a List That Serves You

The list determines the range of outcomes available to your family. Everything after it is just seeing which one arrives.

By the time applications are submitted, the possible outcomes are already fixed. A family cannot receive an offer from a school nobody applied to, and cannot compare offers that do not exist. Every choice made in April of senior year was constrained by a list assembled the previous autumn.

Which is why we treat list construction as the most consequential hour of work in the process, and why it should not be done in a hurry from memory and reputation.

The Idea That Changes the Money

Here is the concept most families have never encountered, and it is worth reading twice.

Institutions use their own money to attract students they want. A student in the middle of a school's applicant pool is an ordinary admit. That same student, with the same transcript and the same scores, applying to a comparable institution where they land near the top of the pool, is a student that institution has a reason to compete for.

Nothing about the student changed. What changed was their position relative to everyone else in the room. That relative position is one of the largest levers on price in the entire process, and it is entirely determined by which schools are on the list.

> *Two schools of nearly identical quality can produce offers tens of thousands of dollars apart for the same student, for no reason other than where that student sits in each pool.*

Balance on Two Axes, Not One

Most advice about list-building covers one axis: likelihood of admission. Some reaches, some targets, some likely schools. That is correct as far as it goes and it is only half the job.

The second axis is cost structure. A list can be perfectly balanced for admission and completely unbalanced financially, which is how a family ends up with five acceptances and nothing they can afford.

A WORKABLE LIST SHAPE

CATEGORY	HOW MANY	WHAT IT IS DOING FOR YOU
Likely	2 to 3	Admission is very probable and the cost is manageable without unusual aid. At least one should be genuinely affordable in the worst case.
Target	3 to 4	Your student is at or above the middle of the pool. This is where merit money most often lives, and it is the category families under-build.
Reach	2 to 3	Admission is uncertain. Worth applying to, and never worth planning around.

Shape rather than prescription. The right number varies by student, by application load, and by how much of the list requires supplemental essays.

The target band is where families most often come up short, and it is the band where the money usually is. A list heavy on reaches and light on targets tends to produce either disappointment or expensive acceptances.

Why You Should Never Have Only One Option

Think about how you would behave at a car dealership.

You find the car you want. You are not going to walk up to the salesperson and announce that you love this car, you need this car, and you are not leaving the lot without it. Everyone understands why. The moment the dealership knows you have no alternative, the conversation about price is finished.

Colleges are not car dealerships, and we do not want to push the comparison further than it deserves. But institutions do have limited aid budgets and they do allocate them toward students they are trying to attract. A school that knows a student is coming regardless has considerably less reason to spend from that budget than a school that knows the student has three other good options.

This is not a trick, and it does not require a family to bluff about anything. It requires only that the alternatives be real. Apply to several comparable schools, and the comparison takes care of itself.

There is a practical dimension too, and it is arguably the larger one. You cannot compare offers you did not receive. You cannot appeal an award without another award to point to. A family with a single acceptance has no information about whether the offer is good, and no standing to ask for more. A family with four has both.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> This is the strongest argument for thinking carefully about binding early decision. Committing to attend a single institution before any offer arrives removes the ability to compare, and it removes the school's reason to compete. For some families that trade is worth making. For a family where cost is a live question, it deserves a real conversation first. Chapter 20 covers the tradeoff in detail.

About the Dream School

Most students have one. That is fine, and we are not going to tell a seventeen year old to stop caring about it.

What we will say to parents is this. A dream school belongs on the list. It does not belong at the center of the plan. The families who struggle most in April are the ones who allowed a single institution to become the definition of success, because every other outcome then arrives as a disappointment rather than as a choice.

The families who do best treat the list as a portfolio. Every school on it is a place the student would genuinely be glad to attend and the family could realistically pay for. When the results come in, they are choosing among good options rather than salvaging a plan.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Build on both axes. Balance the list for admission likelihood and for cost structure at the same time.
- Look hard at where your student sits in each school's pool. That position drives merit money more than almost anything else.
- Strengthen the target band. It is where families under-build and where the money most often is.
- Do not submit a list where only one outcome is acceptable, financially or emotionally.
- Use the College List Builder worksheet in Part Seven. It has columns for all of this.

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PART FOUR

Paying for College

What a family pays for college is not a fixed number handed down by an institution. It is the result of a formula, a set of policies, and a series of decisions your family makes long before an award letter arrives.

IN THIS PART

CHAPTER TWELVE

How College Money Actually Works

Most families spend their energy looking for college money in the place where the least of it is. This chapter is about where it actually comes from.

Two questions come up in nearly every first conversation we have with a family. Where do we find all the scholarships? And which ones are worth the most?

They are reasonable questions, and the answers usually surprise people. So before anything else in this part, it is worth laying out where college money originates and in what proportions.

Four Sources, Very Different Sizes

WHERE COLLEGE MONEY COMES FROM

SOURCE	WHAT IT IS, AND WHAT TO EXPECT
The federal government	Grants, loans, work-study, and education tax credits. Grant programs are targeted at families with substantial demonstrated need. For most middle and upper income families, the federal contribution arrives primarily as loans and tax benefits.
Your state	Most states run at least one grant or scholarship program for residents attending in-state institutions. Eligibility rules and deadlines are set by the state and are frequently earlier than federal ones.
The colleges themselves	Institutional grants and scholarships, both need-based and merit-based, funded out of the school's own budget. For most families this is by a wide margin the largest and most influenceable source.
Private organizations	Outside scholarships from foundations, employers, civic groups, and companies. Real money, generally in smaller amounts, and highly competitive relative to the effort required.

That third row is the answer to both questions families ask. The institutions are where the money is. Everything else in this part exists to help you understand and influence what they offer.

A Word About Outside Scholarships

We are not going to tell you to skip private scholarships. Students win them, and a student with time and organizational discipline can accumulate a meaningful amount, particularly through local awards where the applicant pool is small.

But we want to be honest about the ratio of effort to result. A senior spending fifty hours across the fall applying to national scholarships is competing against enormous pools for awards that are usually modest and frequently one-time. That same fifty hours spent researching how each school on the list awards its own institutional money, and then applying to two additional schools where the student sits near the top of the pool, tends to produce a larger number.

If your student pursues outside scholarships, the practical guidance is to start local. Community foundations, service organizations, employers, religious congregations, and your own high school's list. Smaller pools, better odds, less time per application.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Athletic scholarships are the most persistently overestimated source of college money in America. Only about two percent of high school athletes receive an athletic scholarship to play in college, and most of those are partial rather than full. If athletics is part of your family's financial plan, build the plan so it still works if the scholarship does not materialize. Source: National Collegiate Athletic Association.

Gift Aid and Self-Help Aid Are Not the Same Thing

This distinction matters more than any other vocabulary in this part, and the language used in award letters actively obscures it.

Gift aid is money you do not repay. Grants and scholarships. **Self-help aid** is money you either repay or earn. Loans and work-study.

Both routinely appear under the single heading "financial aid" on an award letter, and both get added into a total that a family then compares against another school's total. A letter offering $30,000 that is mostly grant money and a letter offering $30,000 that is mostly loans are not comparable offers, and they are frequently presented as though they were.

> *When you read an award letter, the first thing to do is separate the money you keep from the money you owe.*

Need-Based and Merit-Based Aid

Institutional money comes in two flavors, and understanding which schools lean on which is what makes a college list financially intelligent.

Need-based aid is awarded on the basis of your family's calculated financial circumstances. The school determines what it believes your family can contribute, subtracts that from its cost, and calls the remainder your demonstrated need. It then decides how much of that need to meet.

That last sentence contains the concept most families have never heard, and it explains a great deal. Institutions differ enormously in what share of demonstrated need they actually meet. A small number of very wealthy schools meet all of it. Many meet somewhere between half and three quarters. Some meet considerably less. Two schools that calculate identical need for the same family can produce offers tens of thousands of dollars apart purely on this policy.

Merit-based aid is awarded on the basis of what the student brings, without regard to financial circumstances. Academic record most commonly, but also artistic, athletic, and other talents. Merit money is available to families at every income level, which is the single most useful thing a high-earning family can know about college funding.

Some institutions publish automatic merit criteria: a stated grade point average and sometimes a test score produce a stated award, with no separate application. Others award competitively through a review process. And a small group of highly selective institutions award almost no merit aid at all, because they have no need to attract students with discounts.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Spend your research effort on how each school on your list awards its own money. That is where the dollars are.
- If your student pursues outside scholarships, start local and treat it as supplementary rather than central.
- Learn the phrase "percentage of need met" and look it up for every school on the list. It is published, and it explains offers that otherwise look arbitrary.
- Do not assume your income rules you out. Merit aid does not consider it.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Student Aid Index and the FAFSA

One form, filed once a year, generates the number that every school uses as its starting point. It is worth getting right.

The Free Application for Federal Student Aid is the entry point to the entire system. It produces a figure called the Student Aid Index, and that figure follows your student to every institution they applied to.

It is also, in our experience, the single most commonly mishandled document in college planning. Not because families are careless, but because it asks unfamiliar questions about unfamiliar categories, usually in the middle of an already overloaded autumn.

What the Student Aid Index Is, and What It Is Not

The Student Aid Index replaced the Expected Family Contribution beginning with the 2024-25 award year. The name change was not cosmetic. The old term implied a bill, and families reasonably read it as one.

The SAI is an index number. Schools subtract it from their cost of attendance to determine demonstrated need, and then decide how much of that need to meet. It is not a promise, not a cap, and not what you will pay. Families frequently pay more than their SAI, sometimes considerably more, depending on how generous the institution is.

Two things follow from that. A low SAI does not guarantee affordability at an expensive school that meets little need. And a high SAI does not close off merit money, which ignores the SAI entirely.

Answering the Question Everyone Asks First

"Do I make too much to qualify for anything?"

For need-based federal grants, quite possibly. Those programs are targeted at families with substantial demonstrated need, and the income thresholds are lower than most people assume. We will not pretend otherwise.

But that is one program among many, and it is the wrong reason to skip the form. File the FAFSA regardless, for four reasons.

- Institutional need-based aid is calculated from it, and institutional thresholds are frequently much higher than federal ones.
- Many colleges require it before awarding merit scholarships, even ones that have nothing to do with need.
- Many state grant programs and outside scholarship sponsors require it.
- It is the gateway to federal student loans, which carry better terms and protections than private ones, and which you may want even if you do not need them.

A family that skips the form because they assume the answer is disqualified from things that had nothing to do with their assumption.

What Changed, and Why Old Advice Misleads

The federal aid system was substantially rewritten beginning with the 2024-25 award year. Several changes are large enough that advice written before them is actively misleading.

NOTABLE CHANGES FAMILIES SHOULD KNOW

WHAT CHANGED	WHY IT MATTERS
Multiple children in college at once	The federal formula no longer reduces a family's number based on how many children are enrolled simultaneously. This was a substantial benefit under the old system and its removal significantly affects families with children close in age.
Family business and farm net worth	No longer reported on the FAFSA for family-owned small businesses, farms, and commercial fisheries. A meaningful improvement for business-owning families.
529 accounts owned by others	Accounts owned by grandparents, aunts, uncles, and other non-parents are not reported, and neither are withdrawals from them under the federal formula.
Sibling 529 accounts	Only 529 assets belonging to the student applying are reported, not those of siblings.

WHAT CHANGED	WHY IT MATTERS
Divorced and separated parents	The parent who provides the most financial support files, using their income and assets. This is a change from the prior custody-based rule and can substantially change the outcome.

Federal financial aid rules are subject to change. Verify current rules at studentaid.gov before relying on any of this for your own filing.

Filing Well

The FAFSA has historically opened on October 1 for the following school year, though recent cycles have varied. Confirm the current opening date rather than assuming, and file close to it.

Filing early matters, but not for the reason that circulates online. Federal aid is not a race in which the money runs out nationally. What is true is narrower: some campus-based funds are limited and awarded until exhausted, many state grant deadlines are early, and errors take weeks to correct. A family that files in October has room to fix a problem. A family that files in February does not.

You file every year your student is enrolled. The income used is from two years prior, so each year's form draws on a different tax year.

THE ERRORS WE SEE MOST

- A digit added or dropped in an income or asset figure. The difference between $20,000 and $200,000 is one keystroke.
- Reporting retirement account balances, which the federal formula does not ask for.
- Reporting home equity in the primary residence, which the federal formula does not ask for either.
- Confusion in divorced, separated, remarried, or never-married households about who is required to file.
- Listing assets in the wrong owner's column, particularly parent assets recorded as student assets.
- Failing to list every school the student applied to.

A practical habit that catches most of this: before submitting, save the completed form as a PDF and read it the following day with fresh eyes, or have a second adult read it. Errors that are invisible at eleven at night are obvious at seven the next morning.

WATCH OUT

Never misstate income or assets. A share of applications are selected for verification each year, and a family found to have misrepresented its finances can lose eligibility for that year and beyond. Everything legitimate happens before you file, not on the form itself. That is the subject of Chapter 16.

None of this is exotic, and the cost of getting it slightly wrong is easy to underestimate. Here is what that looked like for one family.

A FAMILY WE WORKED WITH

Three errors, and what they cost

A family came to us with a younger child and one question: had they paid too much for their older student, already in college? We ran the analysis on the filing already submitted.

We found three errors on the FAFSA. Not misrepresentations, and nothing dramatic. Ordinary mistakes made by attentive people filling out an unfamiliar form. Corrected, those three items would have changed the family's aid by $4,344 a year.

ERRORS FOUND	ANNUAL DIFFERENCE	ACROSS FOUR YEARS
3 On a single submitted FAFSA	$4,344 Had they been corrected	$17,376 For one student

We include this case precisely because it is unglamorous. No strategy, no clever positioning. A form filled out slightly wrong, and it cost a careful family the price of a car.

This is one family's outcome. The effect of any error depends on the family's circumstances and the schools involved, and in many cases an error changes nothing. Nothing here is a projection of what any other family should expect.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- File every year, regardless of income. The reasons to file extend well beyond federal grants.
- Treat the SAI as an index, not a bill. What you actually pay depends on each school's policy.
- Read the completed form a second time on a different day before submitting.
- If your household is divorced, separated, remarried, or blended, get the filing question answered before you start rather than partway through.

The CSS Profile and Institutional Methodology

A few hundred institutions ask a second and much longer set of questions. If any of them are on your list, your planning changes.

The FAFSA determines eligibility for federal aid and gives schools a common starting point. A subset of institutions, mostly private and mostly selective, want considerably more information before they will award their own money. Those schools use the CSS Profile.

Roughly a few hundred colleges and scholarship programs require it. The list changes, and it is published by the College Board. We also maintain a current list of participating institutions as a companion resource.

What It Asks That the FAFSA Does Not

The Profile is not a longer version of the same form. It asks about categories the federal formula deliberately excludes.

- Equity in your primary residence
- Retirement account balances
- The income and assets of a non-custodial parent, at many schools
- Private school tuition being paid for younger siblings
- Unusual medical and dental expenses
- Business and farm net worth, which the FAFSA no longer collects
- 529 accounts owned by grandparents and other relatives

Because the questions are broader, the number a Profile school calculates is typically higher than the federal one, and sometimes substantially so. A family that has looked only at their SAI and concluded they are in good shape can be surprised by an offer from a Profile school.

Institutions also apply their own judgment. Two Profile schools receiving identical information can reach different conclusions, because each one weights the categories according to its own policy. There is no single institutional formula, which is why the Profile is harder to plan around than the FAFSA.

Practical Mechanics

The Profile generally opens earlier in the fall than the FAFSA, and individual schools set their own deadlines, which are often tied to application deadlines rather than to a common date. There is a fee, with waivers available for qualifying families.

Most Profile schools also require supporting documentation, submitted through the College Board's document service. Tax returns, W-2s, and business records are common requests. Budget real time for this. It is frequently more work than the form itself, and it recurs annually.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> If your family is divorced, separated, or never married, check the non-custodial parent policy at every Profile school on the list before your student applies. Some require the non-custodial parent's full financial information, some have a waiver process, and some do not ask at all. Discovering this in January, when a form requires information from someone who may be unwilling to provide it, is a genuinely bad position to be in.

> **WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY**
>
> - Check early whether any school on the list requires the Profile. It changes what a realistic offer looks like.
> - Expect a higher institutional number than your federal one, and plan against that rather than against the SAI alone.
> - Note each school's individual deadline. They do not share one.
> - Resolve the non-custodial parent question before applications go out, not after.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Sticker Price, Cost of Attendance, Net Price, True Cost

Four terms, four different numbers, and only one of them is what your family will actually pay.

The number that drives most early college conversations is the one printed on the school's website. For most families it is also the least relevant number available.

The Four Numbers

WHAT EACH TERM ACTUALLY MEANS

TERM	DEFINITION
Sticker price	Published tuition and fees, before any aid. A list price, not a transaction price. Excludes housing, food, books, and travel.
Cost of Attendance	The school's full estimated annual budget: tuition, fees, housing, food, books, transportation, and personal expenses. This is the figure aid is calculated against, and it is bigger than the sticker price.
Net price	Cost of Attendance minus gift aid. What the family is responsible for covering, whether from savings, income, or borrowing.
True cost	Net price across all four years, accounting for annual increases, scholarship renewal conditions, and any interest on money borrowed. The only number that answers the question families are actually asking.

The gap between the first and the third is wide, and it is wide in a way that regularly changes which schools a family should be considering. An expensive private institution that discounts heavily can end up costing a particular family less than a public university that does not. Sorting schools by sticker price, which is what nearly everyone does first, sorts them by a number that has limited relationship to the outcome.

Net Price Calculators, and When to Use Them

Every college that participates in federal aid programs is required to publish a net price calculator on its website. You enter your family's financial information and the tool estimates what your family specifically would pay at that school.

Most families run these after their student has been admitted. At that point the calculator is confirming a number the award letter is about to deliver anyway.

Run them in sophomore or junior year instead, before the list is set. Used that way, the calculator stops being a prediction and becomes a filter. It tells you which schools are worth applying to and, just as usefully, which apparently expensive schools are more affordable for your family than they look.

> *A net price calculator run in April of senior year is a weather report. Run in tenth grade, it is a map.*

Two cautions. The calculators vary in quality, and some are considerably more detailed than others. And they generally estimate need-based aid well while handling merit aid poorly or not at all, which means a strong student may do better than the calculator suggests.

Why the Four-Year Number Is the One That Matters

Families anchor on the first-year offer. Three things make years two through four different, and all three are knowable in advance.

Costs rise annually. Tuition has increased faster than general inflation for decades. A four-year projection built on the freshman-year figure understates the total.

Scholarships carry renewal conditions. Most merit awards require a minimum grade point average, full-time enrollment, and sometimes continuous enrollment. These conditions are stated in the award letter and are frequently not read. A scholarship lost in sophomore year is a problem with no good solution.

Need-based aid is recalculated every year. A raise, a change in household size, a sibling graduating, or a shift in assets all change the number. This cuts both ways, and it is worth knowing which way yours is likely to move.

WATCH OUT

Some institutions offer more generous aid in the first year than in subsequent ones. Before accepting an offer, ask the financial aid office directly whether the aid package is expected to remain comparable in years two through four, assuming the family's circumstances do not change. Ask it in writing if you can. It is an entirely normal question and the answer occasionally changes a decision.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Stop comparing sticker prices. Compare estimated net prices, which are a different ranking entirely.
- Run net price calculators in sophomore or junior year, while they can still shape the list.
- Build a four-year projection, not a one-year one, and include annual increases.
- Read the renewal conditions on any merit award before your student commits to the school.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Positioning Before You File

The aid formulas do not read your finances the way you do. Knowing how they read them, while you still have time to act on it, is one of the few genuine advantages available to a family.

Two families sit down with us in the same month. Both have a junior in high school. Both earn somewhere near $190,000. Both have been careful with money for two decades and have something to show for it.

One of them is going to pay meaningfully less for college than the other, and it will not be because they found something clever. It will be because they understood how the financial aid formulas were going to read their situation while there was still time to do something about it. The other family will learn the same information in April of senior year, when it has become trivia.

That is what this chapter is about. Not tricks. Sequence.

First, a Word About What This Is Not

Some corner of the college funding industry sells the idea that there is a way to make a family look poorer than it is. There is not. Misreporting income or assets on the FAFSA is fraud. A meaningful share of applications are selected for verification each year, at which point the family is asked to document what they reported. A family caught misrepresenting its finances can lose aid eligibility for that year and for the years that follow.

Nothing in this chapter involves hiding anything. Everything in this chapter involves understanding the consequences of ordinary, legal, documented financial decisions *before* you make them rather than after. That is the entire idea, and it is enough.

The Formulas Do Not Weigh All Money the Same Way

When you file the FAFSA, you are not handing the federal government a portrait of your family's wealth. You are handing it a specific list of inputs. Each input is weighted differently. Several categories of money are not requested at all.

HOW THE FEDERAL FORMULA READS A FAMILY BALANCE SHEET

WHAT YOU HAVE	WHOSE IT IS	HOW MUCH IS COUNTED
Adjusted available income above the protection allowance	Parent	**22% to 47%**
Income above the protection allowance	Student	**50%**
Non-retirement assets above the protection allowance: savings, investments, and 529 accounts for the applicant	Parent	**Up to 5.64%**
Savings, bank accounts, CDs, custodial accounts, and other holdings	Student	**20%**
Qualified retirement account balances	Parent or student	Not reported
Equity in the family's primary residence	Parent	Not reported
529 accounts owned by grandparents, aunts, uncles, and other non-parents	Other	Not reported

Federal methodology for the 2026-27 award year. Source: U.S. Department of Education, studentaid.gov. Protection allowances vary by household size, age, and marital status. Figures are subject to change and should be verified before you rely on them.

Read that table twice, and pay attention to two gaps in particular.

The first is between 5.64 percent and 20 percent. That is the same dollar, sitting in the same kind of account, assessed almost four times as heavily depending on whose name is on it. Families who moved money into a custodial account in a child's name years ago, for perfectly sensible reasons that had nothing to do with college, are often surprised by this one.

The second gap is between the rows that carry a percentage and the rows that say *not reported*. Those categories are not assessed at a low rate. They are outside the calculation entirely.

INCOME IS THE HEAVIER LEVER, BY A WIDE MARGIN

It is worth being blunt about this, because it is where most of the industry's overpromising happens. Income drives the federal calculation far more than assets do. A family with a high income will produce a high Student Aid Index almost regardless of what their balance sheet looks like. There is no version of this where a household earning $300,000 gets repositioned into need-based aid eligibility at a state university, and anyone who suggests otherwise is selling something.

What is true is that income has timing, and timing can be planned around. A bonus, an exercised option, a capital gain, a business distribution, or a retirement account conversion all land in a specific tax year, and one specific tax year is going to determine your student's aid for a given year of college. Which one, and what that means, is the subject of the next section.

THE CSS PROFILE ASKS A LONGER SET OF QUESTIONS

Everything above describes federal methodology. The several hundred institutions that also require the CSS Profile use their own formulas, and those formulas typically ask for home equity, retirement balances, the finances of a non-custodial parent, and other detail the FAFSA leaves alone. A family's institutional number frequently lands higher than their federal one. If schools requiring the Profile are on your student's list, your planning has to account for a second and stricter set of rules.

SEE ALSO CHAPTER 14, THE CSS PROFILE AND INSTITUTIONAL METHODOLOGY

Two Clocks Are Running, and One of Them Started Early

The formulas take a snapshot. Understanding exactly when each part of that snapshot is taken is what separates families who have options from families who have information.

The income clock runs two years ahead. The FAFSA for any given award year uses income from two years earlier. A student entering college in the fall of 2027 will have their first year of aid calculated on the family's 2025 income. That year is already closed. Nothing can be done about it now.

The asset clock runs to a single day. Assets are reported as of the date the form is filed, not as an average over the year. What the family holds, and where, on that particular day is what the formula sees.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> By the time the college process feels urgent to most families, usually somewhere in the middle of junior year, the income year that will determine the first year of aid is already underway or already over. This is the single most common reason families discover their options after those options have expired. It is also the reason our work with families begins in ninth grade rather than eleventh.

There is a second-order version of this that catches families with more than one student. If your children are three years apart, the base income years for their college careers overlap for most of a decade. A financial decision made in a single year can touch both students' aid. Families rarely see that overlap until someone maps it out for them.

What Positioning Actually Looks Like

Strip away the marketing and the work comes down to a small number of honest questions, asked early enough to matter.

Which of your assets currently sit in categories the formulas assess, and which sit in categories they do not? Whose name is on each account, and is that still the right name? Which years of income are going to be scored, and is there anything about the timing of your compensation that you actually control? Do the schools on your student's list use federal methodology alone, or will a second formula be applied to a longer list of questions?

Those questions have real answers. But the answers are different for every family, because they collide with everything else in a household's financial life. Repositioning assets can affect your liquidity, your tax picture, your retirement readiness, and your ability to handle an emergency. A move that produces a better aid outcome and a worse retirement is not a win. It is a trade, and it should be made with open eyes.

> *The right answer for one family is frequently the wrong answer for the family next door with the same income and the same number of children.*

A FAMILY WE WORKED WITH

Twins, $650,000 in savings, and one conversation held in time

A family came to us during their twin daughters' junior year with roughly $650,000 in accumulated savings. They had done everything right for twenty years. They had also placed almost all of that money in accounts the aid formulas assess directly, and they had no idea that the distinction existed.

Working with their timeline, we repositioned $300,000 of it into vehicles that were safer, more liquid, carried better growth potential, and sat outside the categories the formulas count. The money remained fully available to them. They could borrow against it or draw on it as freely as before.

PROJECTED COST, PER STUDENT, PER YEAR	PROJECTED COST, PER STUDENT, PER YEAR	ANNUAL DIFFERENCE ACROSS BOTH STUDENTS
$54,368	$43,602	$21,532
Before repositioning	After repositioning	$10,766 per student, per year

Nothing was hidden and nothing was misreported. The family simply learned, while there was still time, that the formulas were going to read a savings account and a retirement account very differently, and they acted on that before the snapshot was taken rather than after.

This is one family's outcome, and it comes from a specific moment. The engagement took place in 2022 and the daughters enrolled in the fall of 2023, which was the final year of the federal aid system that has since been replaced. Under that older formula, a family's calculated contribution was divided among the number of children enrolled in college at the same time, which mattered a great deal for twins. That provision no longer exists. The asset positioning lever described in this chapter is unchanged, and with the old divider gone it arguably carries more weight now than it did then. But a family in identical circumstances today would see different figures. Every family's income, assets, timeline, and college list are different, and so are the results. Nothing here is a projection of what any other family should expect.

Why This Chapter Stops Where It Does

You may have noticed that we have not named a single financial product in this chapter. That is deliberate, and we want to be straightforward about the reason.

Which instrument fits a specific family, in what amount, funded from which source, and in which calendar year, is not a question a downloadable guide can answer responsibly. It depends on your income and its stability, your existing accounts and their tax treatment, your retirement position, your other children, your comfort with illiquidity, and the specific schools your student is likely to apply to. Any document that hands you a product recommendation without knowing those things is not advising you. It is guessing, and it is guessing with your money.

What a guide can do, and what this one has tried to do, is tell you three things clearly. The lever is real. It is legal. And it has a deadline that arrives earlier than almost anyone expects.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Find out which income year will be scored for your student's first year of college, and count backward from there. If that year is already closed, focus your attention on assets and on the years that follow.
- Look at whose name is on each account. Money held in a student's name is assessed at roughly four times the rate of the same money held by a parent.
- Check whether any school on your student's list requires the CSS Profile. If so, a second and longer set of questions applies, and home equity and retirement balances come back into view.
- Treat any repositioning decision as a whole-household decision. Aid efficiency is one variable among several, and it should not be the only one that wins.

IF YOU WANT A SECOND SET OF EYES

This is the conversation that has a deadline.

Most of what is in this guide you can act on yourself. This chapter is the exception. Mapping which income years will be scored, reviewing how your accounts are currently positioned, and weighing a change against your retirement and tax picture is specific work, and it is worth doing before the snapshot is taken rather than after.

A consultation with a Strategy West advisor costs nothing and commits you to nothing. If your situation does not call for any of this, we will tell you that.

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CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Borrowing, and What It Actually Costs

Borrowing is a legitimate tool and most families use some of it. The damage comes from borrowing without having done the arithmetic first.

There is no virtue in refusing to borrow for education, and there is no shame in it. What there is, reliably, is a difference between families who decided how much to borrow before the offers arrived and families who borrowed whatever the gap turned out to be.

Two Kinds of Debt, and They Are Not Close

Education loans come from two places. The federal government, and everyone else.

Federal loans carry fixed rates set by law, income-driven repayment options, deferment and forbearance provisions, and various discharge and forgiveness programs. Undergraduate loans in the student's name generally require no credit history and no co-signer.

Private loans come from banks, credit unions, and specialty lenders. Rates are frequently variable, are priced on credit, and are typically higher. Repayment protections are whatever the contract says, which in practice is considerably less than the federal programs offer. Most undergraduates need a co-signer, usually a parent, who becomes fully liable.

> *Exhaust federal options before considering private ones. This is one of the few pieces of advice in this guide that holds for essentially every family.*

An Order of Operations

When borrowing is necessary, the sequence below is a reasonable default. It is not a rule, and a family's own circumstances can justify a different order.

- Federal loans in the student's name, subsidized first where the student qualifies, then unsubsidized.
- Family resources that carry no interest and no institutional terms, where they exist and where lending them does not create a different problem.
- Federal parent loans, taken deliberately and with attention to the borrowing limits described below.
- Borrowing against home equity, considered carefully. The rate may be attractive and the collateral is your house.
- Private education loans, last, and after comparing at least three lenders.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Federal borrowing limits changed materially beginning July 1, 2026. Annual and lifetime caps on some federal parent and graduate loans were reduced, and the graduate PLUS program is being phased out. Families who planned around the older, effectively uncapped parent borrowing limits should revisit that assumption. Current limits and rates are in the reference section at the back of this guide, and they change annually.

Two Numbers Worth Deciding in Advance

Before any offer arrives, we ask families to settle on two figures. Not precise ones. Ceilings.

The first is how much the student will borrow in total. A widely used rule of thumb is to keep total student borrowing at or below the salary the student can realistically expect in their first year of work. It is imperfect, it varies by field, and it is far better than no reference point at all. This is where Chapter 9's argument about field and borrowing capacity becomes concrete.

The second is how much the parents will borrow. This is the harder conversation and the one families most often avoid. Parent borrowing has no deferment against your remaining working years. Money borrowed at fifty is repaid on a schedule that runs into your sixties, and it competes directly with retirement saving during the years when retirement saving matters most.

We say this to parents directly, and it is not comfortable. Your student has decades of earning ahead of them and access to income-driven repayment programs. You have fewer years and no equivalent safety net. A family that borrows heavily against the parents' retirement to fund an undergraduate degree has not solved a problem. It has moved the problem forward twenty years and added interest to it.

What Interest Actually Does

Families tend to think in terms of the amount borrowed. Lenders think in terms of the amount repaid, and the gap between those two figures over a standard ten-year term is larger than most people expect.

Two mechanics account for most of it. Subsidized federal loans do not accrue interest while the student is enrolled; unsubsidized loans and parent loans do, which means the balance is already larger on graduation day than the amount borrowed. And most federal loans carry an origination fee deducted at disbursement, so the amount that reaches the school is slightly less than the amount owed.

None of this is a reason to avoid borrowing. It is a reason to run the repayment estimate before signing rather than after. Every federal loan program publishes a repayment estimator, and ten minutes with it changes how a family reads an award letter.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Decide your two ceilings before offers arrive, not while comparing them.
- Exhaust federal options before private ones, and compare at least three lenders if you go private.
- Protect retirement. Your student has time and repayment options that you do not.
- Run a repayment estimate for the full four years, not just the freshman-year figure.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Reading and Comparing Award Letters

Three letters arrive within a few weeks of each other, formatted three different ways, using three different vocabularies. Making them comparable is a skill, and it is learnable in an afternoon.

There is no required format for a financial aid award letter. Institutions choose their own terminology, their own layout, and their own decisions about what to include and what to leave out. Two letters describing materially different offers can look almost identical.

So the first thing to understand is that the letter is not a comparison tool. It is a document produced by one institution, describing one offer, in language of its own choosing. Converting three of them into something comparable is work the family has to do.

What Award Letters Do That Obscures the Picture

- **Loans presented as aid.** Federal loans routinely appear alongside grants under a single heading, and are included in a headline total. Money you owe is not money you received.
- **Cost of Attendance omitted.** Many letters state the aid but not the full cost it is being applied against, which makes the offer look larger than it is.
- **Tuition only, housing excluded.** Some letters quietly compare aid against tuition and fees rather than against total cost.
- **Vague labels.** An award named for a donor tells you nothing about whether it is need-based, merit-based, renewable, or one-time.
- **Renewal conditions buried.** The grade point average required to keep a scholarship is frequently in small type or in a linked document.

The Only Comparison That Works

Reduce every offer to one number, calculated the same way each time.

Start with the school's full Cost of Attendance, not tuition. If the letter does not state it, the financial aid office will, and it is published. Subtract only gift aid: grants and scholarships you do not repay. Ignore loans and work-study entirely at this stage.

What remains is your net cost for one year. That figure is comparable across institutions and almost nothing else on the letter is. Then multiply out four years, adding a reasonable annual increase, and check the renewal conditions on every scholarship in the package.

The Award Letter Comparison Worksheet in Part Seven walks through this in columns.

Reading Composition, Not Just Totals

The most useful habit in this chapter is looking at what an offer is made of rather than what it adds up to. An example makes the point better than an explanation.

Below is a real award, anonymized, shown before and after the family raised questions with the financial aid office. The headline total went up by $2,574, which looks like a modest win. What actually happened is more instructive.

ONE STUDENT'S AWARD, BEFORE AND AFTER

COMPONENT	TYPE	ORIGINAL	REVISED
University achievement award	GIFT	$9,680	$9,680
State access grant	GIFT	$3,000	$3,000
State merit scholarship	GIFT	None	$2,574
Subsidized federal loan	SELF-HELP	$3,500	$2,356
Unsubsidized federal loan	SELF-HELP	None	$1,144
Headline total		**$16,180**	**$18,754**
Gift aid only		**$12,680**	**$15,254**

Anonymized from an actual award letter. School and state identifiers removed. Figures are for one academic year.

Three things are visible here that the headline number hides.

The institution did not give more. Its own achievement award did not move by a dollar. The entire increase came from a state scholarship the student was eligible for and that had not yet been applied to the account. That is worth knowing, because it tells you what kind of conversation to have next and with whom.

The self-help total was unchanged. Borrowing stayed at $3,500 in both versions. The loan portion was simply redistributed.

The loan mix got slightly worse. Subsidized borrowing fell by $1,144 and unsubsidized borrowing appeared in exactly that amount. Subsidized loans do not accrue interest while a student is enrolled; unsubsidized ones do. Same borrowing, marginally worse terms, invisible in the total.

> *A family reading only the bottom line would have learned the wrong lesson from this letter twice over.*

Asking for More

You can ask a financial aid office to reconsider. It is a normal request, it is made by families every year, and it does not jeopardize an admission decision or an existing offer.

It also is not a negotiation in the commercial sense, and framing it that way tends to go badly. What you are doing is providing information the office did not have when it built the package, and asking it to be reviewed in light of that information.

WHEN A FAMILY HAS REAL STANDING

- Household circumstances changed after the filing year: job loss, reduced income, a death, a separation, or a major uninsured expense.
- Something on the form was reported incorrectly and can be documented.
- The family has a materially stronger offer from a genuinely comparable institution.
- Costs the formula did not capture, such as significant medical expenses or support for another family member.

The first and second categories fall under what aid administrators call professional judgment, which is the authority to adjust a family's circumstances based on documented facts the standard formula could not see. It is the strongest ground available.

HOW TO MAKE THE REQUEST

Put it in writing, keep it short, and attach documentation. State what changed or what was missed, state the specific number that would make the school workable, and be respectful about it. Include the competing offer if you have one, as a document rather than a claim.

Then be realistic about outcomes. Some appeals produce nothing. Many produce a modest revision. Occasionally one produces a significant change, usually where a genuine change in circumstances was documented. A family that asks well has lost nothing. A family that never asks has forfeited the entire possibility.

WATCH OUT

Deposit deadlines do not pause for an appeal. If May 1 is approaching and you have not heard back, contact the office, ask directly whether a short extension is possible, and have a fallback school you would be content to attend. Never let an appeal become the reason a family misses a deadline at a school it could actually afford.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Reduce every offer to Cost of Attendance minus gift aid. That number is comparable. Nothing else on the letter is.
- Read composition, not totals. Where the money came from matters as much as how much of it there is.
- Check renewal conditions on every scholarship before your student commits.
- Ask for reconsideration if you have documented grounds. It is normal, it is free, and the worst outcome is a no.

IF THE LETTERS ARE ALREADY ON YOUR TABLE

This part has a deadline, and it is May 1.

Comparing offers correctly and deciding whether you have grounds to ask for more is time-sensitive work, and most families do it once with no basis for comparison. We do it every spring. A consultation will tell you how your offers actually compare and whether an appeal is worth making.

If your offers are already strong and there is nothing to pursue, we will tell you that too, and you will have lost half an hour.

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05

PART FIVE

Applications Through Decision Day

Senior year is where four years of work gets submitted, evaluated, and priced. For families who prepared, it is busy. For families who did not, it arrives all at once.

IN THIS PART

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The Senior Year Map

Nothing about senior year is individually difficult. The difficulty is that all of it lands in the same fourteen weeks.

Ask a family who has just finished senior year what was hardest about it and they rarely name a single task. They name the pile. Applications, essays, recommendation requests, financial aid forms, testing, and an actual course load, all competing for the same October.

The map below is not a to-do list so much as a compression chart. Its purpose is to show you what stacks up where, so that the things which can be moved earlier actually get moved.

SENIOR YEAR, MONTH BY MONTH

WHEN	WHAT IS HAPPENING
Summer before	Finalize the list. Draft the main essay. Complete the activities record. Prepare the material recommenders will need. Retake a test if one more attempt is worth it. This is the month that decides how hard October will be.
August	Applications open. Create accounts, start filling in the mechanical sections, and register for any remaining test dates.
September	Submit FERPA and the final school list to the counseling office. Formally request transcripts and letters. Begin supplemental essays, which are where the real volume is.
October	Financial aid forms open. File the FAFSA and, where required, the CSS Profile. Finish early applications. Check that every requested document has actually been sent.
November	Early deadlines land, commonly on November 1 or November 15. Many priority and scholarship deadlines land here too. Keep grades steady; this term appears on the mid-year report.
December	Early results arrive. Submit remaining regular decision applications before the holiday break rather than during it.
January	Regular deadlines. Mid-year reports go out. Verify each portal shows a complete file, because a missing document is the family's problem to catch.

WHEN	WHAT IS HAPPENING
February and March	Respond to any verification or document requests promptly. Decisions and award letters begin arriving.
April	Compare offers properly. Visit again if it helps. Pursue an appeal if there are grounds, and start early enough to hear back.
May	Deposit by the deadline, typically May 1. Notify the schools you are declining. Send final transcripts and finish the year without coasting.

Individual deadlines vary by institution and change annually. Build your student's actual dates from each school's published calendar.

The Summer Is the Whole Game

Look at that table again and notice how much of it could have happened in July.

The list, the main essay, the activities record, and the material recommenders need are all portable. None of them requires the school year. A student who arrives at August with those four things finished has a manageable autumn. A student who arrives with none of them finished is doing all of it alongside a full course load, in the same weeks that determine the grades on the mid-year report.

> *Every hour of application work done in July is worth roughly two done in October.*

One Person Should Own the Calendar

Senior year involves deadlines set by several institutions, a high school counseling office, two federal or institutional aid systems, and testing agencies. None of them coordinate with each other, and none of them will notice if something is missed.

Decide early who in your household holds the master calendar. For most families it works best if the student owns the applications and essays while a parent owns the financial forms and deadline tracking. What does not work is an assumption that the other person is watching.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Move the list, the essay, the activities record, and recommender materials into the summer. This is the highest-leverage scheduling decision of senior year.
- Build one calendar with every deadline on it, including scholarship and priority dates that differ from application dates.
- Assign ownership explicitly rather than assuming it.
- Protect fall grades. They are reported, and they matter more than most seniors believe.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Early Decision, Early Action, and Regular

When a student applies changes what they are agreeing to. One of these options is a contract, and families sign it without always realizing.

Application plans sound like scheduling choices and are not. They carry different obligations, different admission dynamics, and quite different financial consequences.

APPLICATION PLANS COMPARED

PLAN	WHAT IT MEANS
Early Decision	Binding. If admitted, the student agrees to enroll and to withdraw applications elsewhere. One institution only. Typically decided in December.
Early Action	Not binding. The student applies early, hears early, and retains the right to compare and decide until the spring deadline.
Restrictive or Single-Choice Early Action	Not binding, but limits where else a student may apply early. Rules vary by institution and must be read individually.
Regular Decision	The standard cycle. Deadlines commonly in January, decisions in the spring, deposit by the spring deadline.
Rolling admission	Applications reviewed as they arrive until the class fills. Applying early in the cycle is a genuine advantage here.

The Early Decision Question

Early Decision is the only plan that requires a commitment before any information about cost exists. That is the entire issue, and it deserves a clear-eyed look rather than a rule.

THE CASE FOR IT

Admission rates in early decision rounds are frequently higher than in regular rounds at the same institution. Some of that reflects a genuine advantage and some of it reflects a stronger, more self-selected applicant pool, and reasonable people disagree about the proportions. But institutions do value certainty, and a student who is unambiguously committed is a student the school can count toward its class.

For a family where cost is genuinely not a constraint, and for a student with one clear first choice, Early Decision is a reasonable and often sensible choice.

THE CASE AGAINST IT, FOR MOST FAMILIES

Committing before an offer exists gives up two things at once.

The first is comparison. You will never know what three other institutions would have offered, and you will have no second award to place beside the first. Chapter 18 describes how much information lives in that comparison.

The second is the school's incentive. Institutional aid is used in part to attract students. A school that already has a binding commitment has considerably less reason to spend from that budget than one competing for the same student. This is the point Chapter 11 makes about never having only one option, and Early Decision is the purest form of having only one.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Early Decision agreements generally include a provision releasing a family if the financial aid offered makes attendance impossible. Read the exact language before signing, because it matters what standard is applied and who decides. Being released is not automatic, it is not pleasant, and it should not be treated as a routine escape hatch. If cost is a live question for your family, that provision is a poor substitute for simply not applying under a binding plan.

Early Action Is Usually the Easy Yes

Non-binding early action gets far less attention than it deserves. A student applies early, receives an answer in December or January, and gives up nothing at all. They retain the full right to compare offers in the spring.

The benefits are practical. An acceptance in December materially lowers the temperature in a household. It also frees attention for the remaining applications, and at some institutions early applicants receive earlier or fuller scholarship consideration.

The only real cost is that the application must be finished sooner, which circles back to the previous chapter. A student who used the summer well can apply early action almost everywhere it is offered. A student who did not, cannot.

The Deadline Families Miss

Here is a distinction that costs families real money every year.

At many institutions, the deadline to be considered for scholarships is earlier than the deadline to be considered for admission. A student who applies by the regular January deadline may be admitted in full and be entirely outside the pool for institutional merit money, which closed in November.

Some schools call these priority deadlines. Some attach them to specific named scholarships that require a separate application. Some do not advertise them prominently at all.

> *Check the scholarship deadline separately from the application deadline at every school on the list. They are frequently different, and only one of them is printed in large type.*

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Treat Early Decision as a financial decision, not a scheduling one. If cost is a live question, think hard before applying under a binding plan.
- Use Early Action wherever it is offered and the application is genuinely ready.
- Read restrictive early action rules individually. They differ meaningfully between institutions.
- Look up the scholarship deadline at every school, separately from the admission deadline.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Submitting Well, and Decision Season

The applications go out, and then a long quiet stretch begins. Both halves have work in them.

Assemble the Core Material Once

Most of what goes into an application is the same at every school. Students who do not realize this end up re-entering the same information a dozen times, usually at midnight.

Build one document, early, containing everything reusable. Then every application becomes an exercise in copying and tailoring rather than remembering.

- Full course history with grades, and the school's official course names
- Test dates and scores, including ones the student may not send
- Every activity with the role, the years, and hours per week
- Work history with dates, employers, and responsibilities
- Awards, honors, and recognitions with the year each was received
- Volunteer and community involvement
- The main essay, plus any supplemental essays already drafted
- Names, titles, and contact details for every recommender

This is also the material to hand recommenders and the counseling office. A teacher writing a letter with that document in front of them writes a more specific letter than one working from memory.

The Mechanics That Go Wrong

Applications rarely fail because of the essay. They fail because a document did not arrive.

- **FERPA.** Students are asked whether they waive the right to read their recommendation letters. Waiving is standard, and letters are generally given more weight when the writer knows they are confidential.
- **Requests, not assumptions.** Transcripts, counselor reports, and teacher letters are sent because someone formally requested them through the school's process. Confirm each one was requested correctly.
- **Score sending.** Scores usually go from the testing agency, not from the high school. This is a separate transaction with its own fee and its own lag.
- **The final audit.** Before submitting, read the entire application once from the beginning, out loud if possible. Check that the school's name is right in every supplemental essay. This error is common, it is fatal, and it is entirely preventable.
- **Portal verification.** A week after submitting, log into each school's applicant portal and confirm the file is complete. Missing items appear there, and it is the family's job to notice.

The Quiet Stretch

Between submission and decisions there is a two to three month gap in which families feel there is nothing to do. Three things are worth doing.

Keep the grades up. Mid-year reports are sent, senior year grades are reviewed, and final transcripts are required. Admission offers are conditional and can be withdrawn for a serious decline. This is not common, and it is not rare enough to ignore.

Answer requests immediately. Verification requests and document requests are time-limited, and an unanswered one stalls an entire aid file.

Do the financial preparation. Read Chapter 18 before the letters arrive rather than after. Decide the two borrowing ceilings from Chapter 17 now, while the decision is still abstract and calm.

Reading the Outcomes

Decisions arrive in more than two flavors, and the middle ones confuse families.

A **deferral** from an early round moves the application into the regular pool. It is not a rejection. Send a brief note reaffirming interest, along with any genuine update such as improved grades or a new achievement.

A **waitlist** means the school would take the student if space opens. Movement varies enormously year to year and is impossible to predict. Accept the position if you want it, write once to confirm continued interest, and then plan entirely as though it will not happen. Deposit somewhere else and move on emotionally.

Deciding

When the offers are in, run every one through the comparison in Chapter 18 before anyone discusses feelings about schools. Get to a clean set of four-year net cost figures first. The conversation about which school everyone loves goes considerably better when the numbers are already on the table and nobody is arguing with arithmetic.

Then decide, deposit by the deadline, and tell the other schools. Declining promptly is a courtesy that costs nothing and frees a spot for a student on a waitlist somewhere.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Do not place deposits at more than one school to keep options open. Institutions share enrollment data and treat this as a violation of the commitment, and offers have been withdrawn over it. If you need more time because an appeal is pending, ask the school directly for an extension. That request is legitimate and is frequently granted.

When Nothing Is Affordable

Occasionally every offer is out of reach. It is a hard April, and it is not the end of anything.

Real options exist. Appeal, with documentation, as described in Chapter 18. Look at institutions still accepting applications, since many have space after May 1 and some are generous. Consider starting at a community college with a defined transfer path, which is a legitimate route to the same degree at substantially lower cost. Or take a structured gap year, work, and apply again with better preparation and a better list.

What we would urge you to avoid is borrowing far beyond the ceilings you set, because the alternative felt like failure in April. That decision gets repaid for a decade, and the family making it in a rush almost never has the information they need.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Build the core material document once and reuse it everywhere, including with recommenders.
- Verify every portal a week after submitting. Missing documents are your problem to find.
- Run the numbers before the conversation about preferences. It makes April calmer.
- Deposit at exactly one school, and ask for an extension if an appeal is genuinely pending.

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PART SIX

Enrollment and Beyond

Two questions remain after the deposit is paid. Whether this was the right path in the first place, and what happens once your student is actually there. This part takes both of them seriously.

IN THIS PART

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

When College Is Not the Right Answer

This chapter is in a college planning guide on purpose. It is the conversation we have with families more often than any other, and almost nobody in our industry writes it down.

Every so often a family sits down with us and the picture is clear within twenty minutes. The parents want their child to go to college. They want it badly, for reasons that are usually loving and sometimes personal. And the student across the table does not want it, or does not have the record to make it work, or both.

Nobody has said this out loud yet. The parents have been hoping something will click. The student has been going along with it.

At that point we have a choice. We can enroll the family, take the fee, and do good work that will not matter because the student is not going to do their part. Or we can say the harder thing.

> *We say the harder thing. It is the single clearest way we know to demonstrate that our interest and your family's interest are the same thing.*

What Pushing Actually Costs

The instinct to push comes from a good place. College improves outcomes on average across almost every measure that matters, and a parent who wants that for their child is not wrong to want it.

But averages describe populations, not the student in your kitchen. And the downside case is worse than most families realize, because the worst outcome in higher education is not skipping college. It is starting and not finishing.

STUDENTS WHO DO NOT COMPLETE A BACHELOR'S DEGREE WITHIN SIX YEARS	WHAT THAT LEAVES BEHIND
~36%	Debt
First-time, full-time students at four-year institutions	Without the credential the debt was taken on to obtain

Source: U.S. Department of Education, National Center for Education Statistics. Completion rates vary widely by institution.

A student who leaves after three semesters carries the loans and none of the credential. They also carry something harder to quantify, which is the experience of having failed at the first thing they were sent out into the world to do. We have met adults in their thirties still carrying that, and it did not have to happen.

Two Different Situations, Frequently Confused

Before going further, it is worth separating two things that look alike and are not.

Not ready yet describes a student who could do this well but is eighteen and not there. Maturity arrives on its own schedule. For these students the answer is often timing rather than direction: a gap year with structure, a year of work, a semester at a community college while living at home. Many come back to a four-year program at twenty and outperform who they would have been at eighteen.

Not the right path describes a student whose interests, aptitudes, and goals genuinely point somewhere other than a four-year degree. This is not a lesser category and it should not be discussed as one. Some of the most financially secure and professionally satisfied people we know took a different route entirely.

The distinction matters because the responses are different. Confusing them means either rushing a student who needed a year, or spending four years and a great deal of money proving something the family already suspected.

The Alternatives, Named Plainly

Families are often surprised at how substantial these are, because nobody presents them seriously at a college night.

PATHS WORTH TAKING SERIOUSLY

PATH	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Trade and technical programs	Electrical, plumbing, HVAC, welding, automotive and diesel, medical and dental technology, aviation maintenance. Short programs, strong regional demand, and skills that are difficult to outsource or automate.
Registered apprenticeships	Paid employment combined with structured instruction, ending in a recognized credential. The student earns while training rather than borrowing to train.
Military service	Training, a credential in many specialties, and substantial education benefits afterward for students who later decide they want a degree. A significant commitment that deserves an equally significant conversation.
Direct entry to work	Employer-sponsored training and internal advancement, particularly in logistics, sales, hospitality, public safety, and skilled services. Many employers also pay tuition for employees who choose to study later.
Building a business	Rarer and legitimate. A student already running something real, generating revenue and learning constantly, may be getting a better education than a reluctant freshman.
Community college	Genuinely lower cost, open enrollment, and a defined transfer path in most states. Worth its own discussion, below.

Community College Is Not a Consolation Prize

It gets treated as one, and the framing costs families money and students confidence.

Two years at a community college followed by two years at a four-year institution produces the same bachelor's degree, from the institution that grants it, at substantially lower total cost. For a student who is uncertain, it also lowers the stakes of that uncertainty considerably. A student who discovers in their third semester that they chose wrong has lost far less at a community college than at a private university.

Two cautions, both manageable. Confirm the transfer agreement in writing before enrolling, because credits transfer well within a state system and less predictably outside one. And take the sequence seriously, because community college works best when a student treats it as the first two years of a degree rather than as time being served.

A Gap Year, Done Properly

There is a difference between a gap year and a year off, and it is entirely about structure.

A gap year has a plan: employment, a program, service, or training, with defined hours and someone other than a parent holding the student accountable. Students come back from these more focused and frequently more academically successful than they would have been.

A year off has none of that, and it tends to become two. If your family is considering this route, write down what the year contains before it starts. Many colleges will also defer an admission offer for a year, which is worth asking about while the offer is live.

How to Have This Conversation

A few things we have learned from being in the room.

- Ask your student what they want, and then be quiet long enough for a real answer. Teenagers are practiced at giving parents the answer that ends the conversation.
- Separate your disappointment from their decision. Both can be real. Only one of them should be driving.
- Be specific about money. "We have set aside this amount, and it can be used for a degree or for training" changes the conversation entirely.
- Do not frame an alternative as a fallback. A student who takes a path presented as failure carries that framing into it.
- Leave the door open. Choosing not to enroll at eighteen forecloses nothing. Adults enroll every year and generally do better than they would have at eighteen.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Ask honestly whether your student wants this, and distinguish not ready yet from not the right path.
- Look at the alternatives with real attention rather than as a courtesy before returning to the plan.
- If you proceed anyway, proceed with your eyes open and manage the borrowing accordingly.
- Remember that the worst financial outcome in higher education is debt without a degree, and that outcome is more common than most families assume.

IF YOU ARE NOT SURE

We would rather tell you the truth than take the engagement.

If you have read this chapter and recognized your own family in it, that is worth a conversation before you spend anything. We will look at your student honestly, tell you what we see, and say so plainly if we think a different path serves them better. We have turned families away for exactly this reason and we will keep doing it.

And if your student is ready and it simply has not looked that way from inside the house, we will tell you that too.

meetings-na2.hubspot.com/will-smethurst/swfcp-college-planning-guide

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Summer Before

The deposit is paid and the hard part feels finished. There is one more round of decisions, and a few of them carry real money.

The summer between high school and college is mostly logistics, with one genuinely important conversation buried inside it.

The Logistics

- **Orientation and registration.** Attend, and go in with a rough plan for first-semester courses. Advising slots are short and students who arrive with questions get better schedules.
- **Placement testing.** Take it seriously. Placement into a remedial course costs a semester of tuition for credit that does not count toward the degree.
- **Credit evaluation.** Confirm in writing how the school is applying any credit earned in high school, and to which requirements. Do not assume it landed where you expected.
- **Housing and roommates.** Deadlines are earlier than families expect and the good options fill.
- **Health.** Immunization records, the school health plan enrollment or waiver, prescriptions transferred to a local pharmacy, and, if relevant, a plan for continuing mental health care.
- **Documents.** A bank account the student controls, a debit card, and copies of essential records.

On the shopping question: buy considerably less than the lists suggest. Most of what a student needs is available near campus, and a half-empty residence hall room in September is easier to fix than a full one.

The Conversation That Should Happen in July

Somewhere in this summer, sit down and be explicit about money. Not the tuition bill, which the family has already worked through. The ordinary week-to-week questions that otherwise get resolved by accident in October.

- Who pays for what, specifically. Books, travel home, food beyond the meal plan, clothing, entertainment.

- Roughly how much money exists per month, and what happens when it is gone.
- Whether the student will work, how many hours, and whether that is expected or optional.
- What the family expects in return for what it is spending. Say it plainly rather than leaving it implied.

Many students arrive at college having never managed a monthly budget. The first semester is an expensive place to learn, and the conversation is considerably easier in July than in November when the money is already gone.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Financial aid typically disburses to the student's account a few weeks into the term, after the bill has been applied. That means books, supplies, and early expenses often have to be covered out of pocket at the start of the semester and reimbursed later. Plan for that gap rather than discovering it.

The Part That Is Not Logistics

This is the last summer of your student living in your house as a child, and both of you know it. It tends to produce friction that neither side expects, often over curfews and independence that have suddenly become negotiable.

It helps to name it out loud. A conversation that acknowledges the transition directly usually goes better than three months of small arguments standing in for it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

What Freshman Year Actually Feels Like

Written for the parent, because the parent is the one who will be on the phone in October wondering how much to intervene.

Freshman year follows a rhythm that is remarkably consistent across students and institutions. Knowing the shape of it in advance makes the difficult parts less alarming.

The Academic Adjustment

The most common surprise is that high school study habits stop working. Class hours drop sharply, unstructured time increases, and nobody notices if a student falls behind. Students who succeeded on ability alone often struggle first, because they never had to build a method.

The first disappointing grade usually arrives in October, and it lands hard on students who have never received one. It is normal and it is recoverable, and the students who recover are the ones who change how they work rather than working longer at the same thing.

The October Dip

Six to eight weeks in, the novelty wears off and the reality settles. This is when homesickness peaks, when friendships formed in week one turn out to be provisional, and when a student calls home sounding unlike themselves.

It is nearly universal and it is usually temporary. What helps is encouraging your student to stay through a few weekends rather than coming home every one, since the students who leave every Friday take considerably longer to build a life there.

What does not help is solving it for them. What does help is asking questions, staying calm, and pointing toward the resources below.

The Resources Nobody Uses

Every institution provides services your family is already paying for and that most students never touch.

- **Office hours.** The single most underused resource in higher education. Most faculty sit alone during them.
- **Tutoring and writing centers.** Free, staffed, and generally not busy.
- **Academic advising.** Course sequencing, requirements, and the answer to whether a plan actually leads to graduation on time.
- **Counseling services.** Included in fees at nearly every institution.
- **Career services.** Most students discover this office as seniors, which is roughly two years late.
- **Disability and accommodation services.** Accommodations do not transfer automatically from high school. The student must register, and it is worth doing early.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Once your student is enrolled, federal privacy law generally prevents the institution from sharing grades or records with you without the student's written consent, regardless of who is paying. Most schools have a release form. Whether to complete it is a family decision, and it is a much calmer conversation to have in August than in December when a grade report has not arrived.

How Much to Intervene

The general rule is to let your student handle their own problems with professors, roommates, and administrators, and to hold your intervention for genuine emergencies.

This is harder than it sounds when you are writing the checks. But a student who learns to email a professor, dispute a bill, or request a room change is acquiring a skill that matters more than the outcome of the particular dispute. Coach from a distance. Ask what they plan to do, and then let them do it.

The exception is real and worth stating clearly. Signs of serious mental health difficulty, substance problems, or a student who has stopped attending classes are not situations to coach through from a distance. Call the dean of students office. It exists for this, and families are often surprised at how responsive it is.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Staying on Track, and Renewing Aid

The financial plan you built does not run itself. Two things have to keep happening every year, and both are easy to let slip.

The Arithmetic of Graduating on Time

Most bachelor's degrees require roughly 120 credits. Full-time status is usually defined as twelve credits per term, and a student who takes twelve credits every semester for four years finishes with ninety-six. That is not a degree.

Graduating in four years generally requires about fifteen credits per semester, or twelve plus summer coursework. This is simple arithmetic that an enormous number of families never do, and it explains a meaningful share of fifth years.

> *Twelve credits is full-time. Fifteen is on schedule. They are not the same thing, and only one of them graduates in four years.*

Two other things add semesters. Failing or withdrawing from a course in a prerequisite chain can delay everything downstream by a full year if the course runs only once annually. And changing majors is inexpensive within a related field and expensive across an unrelated one, for the same reason.

Internships Start Earlier Than Families Expect

Students commonly assume internships are a junior year concern. In many fields the competitive ones recruit a full year ahead, which means junior year opportunities are pursued during sophomore year.

Encourage a visit to career services in the first year. Not because a freshman will land a competitive internship, but because they will learn the actual timeline while there is still time to act on it.

Renewing Aid, Every Single Year

This is the part families forget, and it is the most expensive thing in this chapter.

- **File again annually.** The FAFSA, and the CSS Profile where required, must be submitted every year your student is enrolled. Each year uses a different income year.
- **Watch the renewal conditions.** Merit scholarships typically require a minimum grade point average and full-time enrollment. Read the exact terms and know the number.
- **Satisfactory academic progress.** Federal aid requires maintaining a minimum standard of grades and completion pace. Falling below it can suspend aid entirely, usually with an appeal process available.
- **Report changes.** A significant change in family circumstances is grounds for a professional judgment review at any point, not only at the start.
- **Watch the aid trajectory.** If year two comes back materially worse than year one without a change in circumstances, ask why. Sometimes there is an explanation and sometimes there is an error.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> A scholarship lost to a grade point average that fell below the renewal threshold is difficult to recover, and many institutions do not restore it once forfeited. If your student is drifting toward the line, that is a conversation to have in November, not after final grades post.

When Transferring Is the Right Call

Sometimes a school genuinely is not working. Transferring is legitimate and a great many students do it successfully.

Do it deliberately. Confirm exactly which credits transfer before committing, because losing a semester of credit erases much of the benefit. Understand that merit scholarships generally do not follow a student, and that transfer aid at the receiving institution is often less generous than first-year aid. And separate a school problem from a student problem honestly, because a difficulty that travels with the student will simply reappear at the next institution.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Check credits per semester against the degree requirement in the first year, not the third.
- Refile financial aid forms every year, on time, without waiting to be reminded.
- Know the exact renewal threshold on every scholarship and track it during the term.
- Send your student to career services as a freshman so they learn the real recruiting timeline.

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PART SEVEN

The Roadmap and the Toolkit

Everything to this point has been explanation. What follows is the working material: a year-by-year plan, printable worksheets, and the vocabulary you will need. These are the pages families actually use.

IN THIS PART

The Year-by-Year Roadmap

Six pages covering the summer before ninth grade through the first year of college, organized by season and by pillar.

The pages that follow are the spine of this guide. Everything in Parts One through Six explains why a particular item matters. These pages tell you when to do it.

How to Use These Pages

- **Start where your student is.** Find the current year, work from there, and then look backward at the previous year to catch anything worth catching up on. Most items can be recovered late; a few cannot, and the tables in Chapter 3 tell you which.
- **Read across, not down.** Each row is a season. The three columns are the three pillars, and the point of the layout is that all three are running at once.
- **Follow the chapter references.** The small notation in each item points to the chapter that explains it.
- **Print these six pages.** They are designed to be pulled out and kept somewhere visible. There is also a blank version in the worksheets for your family's own dates.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Specific dates and deadlines change every year, and they vary by institution and by state. Treat this roadmap as the sequence, not as the calendar. Build your student's actual calendar from each school's published dates and from the current federal and state deadlines.

ROADMAP

The Summer Before Ninth Grade

Nothing here is urgent. Everything here is worth an afternoon, and each item removes a constraint that would otherwise appear years later.

ACADEMIC

- Pull the high school course catalog and map the sequence all the way to twelfth grade, particularly mathematics and world language. Ch 4
- Confirm ninth grade placement is where it should be. Placement decisions made now determine what is available as a senior. Ch 4
- Ask the school how it calculates grade point average, and whether it weights. Ch 5
- Find out what concurrent enrollment and advanced coursework the school offers, and in which years. Ch 4

SOCIAL

- Identify two or three activities worth trying in the fall. The goal this year is exploration, not commitment. Ch 7
- Start a simple running record of activities, roles, and hours. It takes five minutes a term and saves a week in senior year. Ch 21

FINANCIAL

- Calculate the scored income year: take the fall your student will enroll and subtract two. If that year has not happened yet, an entire category of planning is still open to you. Ch 3, 16
- Look at where college savings currently sit and whose name is on each account. Ch 16
- Run a net price calculator once, at any school, simply to see how the numbers behave. Ch 15
- Have the first honest family conversation about what you can contribute. Ch 17

ROADMAP

Ninth Grade

Foundation year. Grades begin counting, habits form, and the activities that will carry four years of depth get chosen.

SEASON	ACADEMIC	SOCIAL	FINANCIAL
FALL	• Establish study habits deliberately rather than by default • Introduce yourself to the counselor Ch 1 • Confirm the four-year course map Ch 4	• Join two or three activities at club rush Ch 7 • Commit to trying them, not to keeping them	• Learn how the aid formulas categorize assets Ch 16 • Confirm which income year will be scored Ch 16
WINTER	• Review first semester grades honestly Ch 5 • Adjust the course load if it is genuinely too heavy Ch 4	• Narrow to the activities worth continuing Ch 7 • Drop what is not working now, not in eleventh grade	• Review whose name is on each savings account Ch 16 • Note that student-held assets are assessed far more heavily
SPRING	• Register for tenth grade, protecting the math and language sequences Ch 4	• Plan the summer: work, a program, or a project Ch 7	• Run net price calculators for one public and one private school to calibrate expectations Ch 15
SUMMER	• Read widely; consider a light academic experience if one appeals	• Work, volunteer, or build something Ch 7 • Update the activities record Ch 21	• Family conversation about what you can contribute and what you expect in return Ch 17

ROADMAP

Tenth Grade

The year the financial levers are still fully open and almost nobody uses them. Also the year direction should start to appear.

SEASON	ACADEMIC	SOCIAL	FINANCIAL
FALL	• Take the PSAT if offered, purely as a diagnostic Ch 6	• Deepen involvement in the activities that stuck Ch 7 • Look for responsibility, not titles	• If the scored income year has not started, plan around it now Ch 16
WINTER	• Assess grades and rigor together Ch 4, 5 • Begin planning eleventh grade coursework Ch 4	• Start career exploration: conversations with adults who do the work, and a shadow day Ch 9	• Review asset positioning while the window is fully open Ch 16
SPRING	• Register for eleventh grade Ch 4 • Sit a full timed practice SAT and ACT, compare, and choose one Ch 6	• Narrow to ten to fifteen careers of interest, then two to four fields of study Ch 9	• Run net price calculators for three to five schools Ch 15
SUMMER	• Begin structured test preparation Ch 6	• Work, program, or project connected to the emerging interest Ch 7	• Check direct-admit policies for any competitive program of interest Ch 9

ROADMAP

Eleventh Grade

The heaviest year. Testing, the list, and the recommendation requests all belong here, and the summer at the end carries more than any other.

SEASON	ACADEMIC	SOCIAL	FINANCIAL
FALL	• Take the PSAT. This is the year it determines National Merit consideration Ch 6 • Continue structured preparation	• Take on real responsibility in the two or three sustained activities Ch 7	• The income year for freshman-year aid has now closed. Shift attention to assets and to the list Ch 16
WINTER	• First official SAT or ACT, after real preparation rather than as a trial Ch 6	• Name the through-line in the student's record Ch 8 • Identify likely recommenders Ch 8	• Build the preliminary list with net price and merit generosity as columns Ch 11
SPRING	• Register for senior courses; keep rigor up Ch 4 • Retake if the first result warrants it Ch 6	• Ask two teachers for letters now, before the fall crush Ch 8 • Visit campuses while school is in session Ch 10	• Look up scholarship and priority deadlines separately from application deadlines Ch 20
SUMMER	• Second test attempt. The least contested preparation window in the calendar Ch 6	• Draft the main essay Ch 8 • Complete the core application material Ch 21	• Finalize the list on both axes Ch 11 • Verify which schools require the CSS Profile Ch 14

ROADMAP

Twelfth Grade

Execution year. For families who used the previous summer well, this is busy rather than overwhelming.

SEASON	ACADEMIC	SOCIAL	FINANCIAL
FALL	• Hold grades steady; this term appears on the mid-year report Ch 21 • Third test attempt if it is worthwhile Ch 6	• Supplemental essays, which are where the volume is Ch 21 • Submit FERPA and formal transcript and letter requests Ch 21	• File the FAFSA as soon as it opens, and the CSS Profile where required Ch 13, 14 • Meet scholarship and priority deadlines Ch 20
WINTER	• Mid-year reports go out. Do not coast Ch 21	• Submit remaining applications before the holiday break Ch 19	• Verify every portal shows a complete file Ch 21 • Respond to verification requests immediately Ch 13
SPRING	• Finish strong. Offers are conditional and can be withdrawn Ch 21	• Revisit finalists if it will help the decision Ch 10	• Compare offers on gift aid only Ch 18 • Appeal with documentation if there are grounds Ch 18 • Deposit at exactly one school by the deadline Ch 21
SUMMER	• Placement testing, taken seriously Ch 23 • Confirm in writing how outside credit is being applied Ch 23	• Orientation, housing, and roommate deadlines Ch 23	• Hold the money conversation before move-in Ch 23 • Plan for the disbursement gap at term start Ch 23

ROADMAP

Freshman Year of College

The planning does not stop at enrollment. This year sets the pattern for the three that follow, financially and academically.

SEASON	ACADEMIC	SOCIAL	FINANCIAL
FALL	• Fifteen credits, not twelve, if a four-year finish is the goal Ch 25 • Go to office hours in the first month Ch 24	• Stay through weekends while a life is being built Ch 24 • Register with accommodation services if relevant Ch 24	• Write down the exact renewal threshold for every scholarship Ch 25
WINTER	• Assess the semester honestly and change method rather than hours Ch 24	• Visit career services to learn the actual recruiting timeline Ch 25	• File the FAFSA again for next year as soon as it opens Ch 25
SPRING	• Register with the full degree map in front of you Ch 25	• Apply for summer work or an internship Ch 25	• Compare the year two offer against year one and ask why if it dropped Ch 25
SUMMER	• Consider summer credits to stay on the 120-credit track Ch 25	• Work or intern in the direction of the field Ch 25	• Report any material change in circumstances for a professional judgment review Ch 25

WORKSHEET 01

Family Readiness Assessment

An honest inventory of where your family stands across the three pillars. There is no score and no passing mark. The value is in seeing which column your checks cluster in.

Student ____________ Grade ____________ Date ____________

STATEMENT	YES	PARTLY	NOT YET
ACADEMIC			
We have mapped the course sequence through twelfth grade			
We know both the weighted and unweighted grade point average			
We have a testing plan with dates and a preparation window			
We know how rigor is reported by our high school			
SOCIAL			
Our student has two or three sustained commitments			
There is visible growth in responsibility over time			
We can name the through-line in our student's record			
Recommenders have been identified			
FINANCIAL			
We know which income year will be scored for freshman year			
We know whose name is on each savings account			
We have run net price calculators for schools on the list			
We know which schools on the list require the CSS Profile			
We have agreed on a ceiling for student and parent borrowing			

THE QUESTION THAT MATTERS MOST

Which single item above, if resolved this month, would change the most for your family, and does it have a deadline you are currently unaware of?

WORKSHEET 02

Your Own Planning Grid

A blank version of the roadmap. Fill it in with your student's actual dates, drawn from your high school calendar and from the published deadlines at the schools on your list. Print one for each grade.

Student ____________________ Grade ____________________ School year ____________________

SEASON	ACADEMIC	SOCIAL	FINANCIAL
Fall			
Fall			
Winter			
Winter			
Spring			
Spring			
Summer			
Summer			

DEADLINES WE MUST NOT MISS THIS YEAR

WORKSHEET 03

College List Builder

Build the list on both axes at once. Aim for two or three likely, three or four target, and two or three reach schools, with at least one that is genuinely affordable in the worst case. Note that the scholarship deadline is frequently earlier than the application deadline.

SCHOOL	L / T / R	EST. NET PRICE	% NEED MET	MERIT?	APP DEADLINE	SCHOLARSHIP DEADLINE

CHECK BEFORE YOU SUBMIT

- ☐ Every school on this list is one our student would genuinely be glad to attend
- ☐ Every school on this list is one we could realistically pay for
- ☐ The target band has at least three schools in it
- ☐ If a direct-admit program is involved, we have confirmed the policy at each school
- ☐ We have checked which of these require the CSS Profile

WORKSHEET 04

Award Letter Comparison

Convert three incomparable letters into one comparable number. Start from Cost of Attendance, not tuition. Subtract only gift aid. Ignore loans and work-study until after you have the net cost line.

LINE ITEM	SCHOOL A	SCHOOL B	SCHOOL C
School name			
Full Cost of Attendance			
Institutional grant			
Institutional scholarship			
Federal or state grant			
Outside scholarship			
Total gift aid			
Net cost, year one			
Subsidized loan offered			
Unsubsidized loan offered			
Parent loan offered			
Work-study offered			
Scholarship renewal GPA			
Other renewal conditions			
Four-year net cost estimate			

GROUNDS FOR ASKING THE SCHOOL TO RECONSIDER

- [ ] Household circumstances changed after the scored income year, and we can document it
- [ ] Something was reported incorrectly and we can document the correction
- [ ] A genuinely comparable institution has offered materially more
- [ ] We have costs the formula did not capture, such as significant medical expenses

WORKSHEET 05

Campus Visit Question Sheet

Go while classes are in session. Walk away from the tour route. Find two or three students who are not employed by the admissions office, and ask them the questions in the second section.

School

Date of visit

ASK THE ADMISSIONS OFFICE

Who teaches first-year courses, and how large are they?

How does academic advising work, and how often do students meet an advisor?

What share of students graduate in four years, and what usually delays the rest?

If our student wants to enter a competitive program later, how does that work and how often does it succeed?

ASK ACTUAL STUDENTS

What do people here do on a Saturday?

What is the thing you wish you had known before you came?

How easy is it to get the classes you need to graduate on time?

How do students here find internships, and who actually helps?

What kind of student is not happy here?

WORKSHEET 06

Financial Aid Office Question Sheet

A separate conversation from the admissions one, and a separate sheet on purpose. These questions are entirely normal to ask, and the answers occasionally change a decision.

School

Spoke with

Date

What percentage of demonstrated need does the school typically meet?

Do you require the CSS Profile, and is there a non-custodial parent requirement?

Is there a scholarship or priority deadline that is earlier than the application deadline?

Do you award automatic merit scholarships, and what are the published criteria?

Assuming our circumstances do not change, would you expect the aid package to remain comparable in years two through four?

What are the renewal conditions on each scholarship, and what happens if they are not met?

How does an outside scholarship affect the package? Does it reduce our grant aid?

What is your process if a family's financial circumstances change after filing?

When does aid disburse, and what will we need to cover out of pocket at the start of term?

WORKSHEET 07

Annual Renewal Checklist

For each year your student is enrolled. This is the page families forget, and forgetting it is the most expensive habit in Part Six.

Student ______________________ Academic year ______________________

FORMS

- [ ] FAFSA filed for the coming year, as soon after opening as possible
- [ ] CSS Profile filed where required, by each school's own deadline
- [ ] Supporting documentation submitted and confirmed received
- [ ] State grant application filed, if separate
- [ ] Outside scholarships reapplied for, since most do not renew automatically

CONDITIONS

- [ ] Scholarship renewal grade point average confirmed and currently met Required: ____________
- [ ] Enrollment status meets the requirement, typically full-time
- [ ] Satisfactory academic progress standard reviewed and met
- [ ] Credits on pace for the degree requirement Earned to date: ____________

REVIEW

- [ ] This year's award compared against last year's, line by line
- [ ] Any unexplained reduction questioned with the financial aid office
- [ ] Material change in family circumstances reported for professional judgment review
- [ ] Borrowing this year checked against the ceilings the family set

NOTES

Glossary

Current terminology, in plain language. Where a term was recently replaced, the older one is noted so you can recognize outdated advice.

Award letter

A school's statement of the aid it is offering. Not standardized, and frequently mixes gift aid with loans under one total.

Common Data Set

A standardized report most institutions publish covering admission rates, score ranges, and aid awarded. Search the school name plus the term.

Cost of Attendance

The school's full estimated annual budget: tuition, fees, housing, food, books, transportation, and personal expenses. Aid is calculated against this figure.

CSS Profile

A supplementary aid application used by a few hundred institutions. Asks about home equity, retirement balances, and other items the FAFSA excludes.

Demonstrated interest

Whether an applicant has engaged with a school. Tracked at some institutions as a tiebreaker, not considered at all at others.

Direct admit

A program entered at the point of admission rather than later. Common in nursing, engineering, business, and architecture.

Early Action

Applying and hearing early without any obligation to enroll.

Early Decision

A binding commitment to enroll if admitted. One school only.

EFC

Expected Family Contribution. The former federal figure, replaced by the Student Aid Index. Advice using this term predates the current system.

FAFSA

Free Application for Federal Student Aid. Filed annually, and the entry point to nearly all aid.

FERPA

The federal privacy law governing education records. Relevant twice: waiving access to recommendation letters, and parental access to college grades.

Gift aid

Money you do not repay. Grants and scholarships.

Institutional methodology

A school's own formula for awarding its own money. Differs from the federal formula and varies between institutions.

Merit-based aid

Awarded for what the student brings rather than financial circumstances. Available at every income level.

Need-based aid

Awarded on calculated financial circumstances.

Need met, percentage of

The share of demonstrated need a school typically covers. Varies enormously and explains offers that otherwise look arbitrary.

Net price

Cost of Attendance minus gift aid. The comparable number across schools.

Net price calculator

A required tool on every participating school's site estimating what your family specifically would pay.

Origination fee

A percentage deducted from a federal loan at disbursement, so slightly less arrives than is owed.

Pell Grant

The primary federal need-based grant, targeted at families with substantial demonstrated need.

PLUS loan

A federal loan for parents of dependent undergraduates. Borrowing limits changed beginning July 1, 2026.

Priority deadline

A date, often earlier than the application deadline, after which scholarship consideration closes.

Professional judgment

A financial aid administrator's authority to adjust a family's circumstances based on documented facts the standard formula cannot see.

Renewal conditions

The requirements to keep a scholarship, typically a minimum grade point average and full-time enrollment.

Rolling admission

Applications reviewed as they arrive until the class fills. Applying early genuinely helps.

Satisfactory academic progress

The minimum grades and completion pace required to keep federal aid. Falling below it can suspend aid.

Scored income year

The tax year used for a given award year, two years prior. Take the enrollment fall and subtract two.

Self-help aid

Money you repay or earn. Loans and work-study.

Sticker price

Published tuition and fees before aid. A list price, not a transaction price.

Student Aid Index

The current federal figure, replacing the EFC. An index used to calculate eligibility, not a bill. Families frequently pay more than it.

Subsidized loan

A federal student loan that does not accrue interest while the student is enrolled.

Superscore

Combining a student's best section results across multiple test sittings. Policies vary by school.

True cost

Net price across four years, including annual increases and interest on anything borrowed.

Unsubsidized loan

A federal student loan that accrues interest from disbursement, including while enrolled.

Verification

A process in which a family is asked to document what it reported. A share of applications are selected each year.

Waitlist

A holding position offered when a school would admit a student if space opens. Movement varies enormously year to year.

Work-study

Aid earned through part-time employment, usually on campus. Self-help aid, not gift aid.

Where to Verify Anything

Do not take our word for it, and do not take anyone else's either. Every figure in this guide can be checked at its source.

College funding rules change, sometimes substantially and sometimes in the middle of a cycle. The single most useful habit a family can build is going to the primary source before acting on anything, including anything in this document.

PRIMARY SOURCES, BY QUESTION

WHEN YOU NEED	GO TO
Federal aid rules, forms, deadlines, and loan terms	The U.S. Department of Education's federal student aid site. Everything about the FAFSA, the Student Aid Index, grant programs, and federal loan limits and rates originates here.
Which schools require the CSS Profile	The College Board's published list of participating institutions. We also maintain a current version as a companion resource.
What a specific school will cost your family	That school's own net price calculator, on its own website. No third-party estimate substitutes for it.
A school's admission and aid statistics	That school's Common Data Set, plus its financial aid office directly for anything the document does not answer.
Graduation rates, retention, and earnings by field	Federal outcomes data published by the U.S. Department of Education.
State grant programs and deadlines	Your state's higher education agency. Deadlines are frequently earlier than federal ones and are set independently.
Test dates, registration, and score policies	The testing agency directly, and each school's published testing policy, which can differ from the general practice.

WATCH OUT

A great deal of college funding content online describes the system that existed before the 2024–25 award year. The fastest test is vocabulary. If a source refers to your family's EFC rather than the Student Aid Index, or describes a benefit for having multiple children enrolled at the same time, it has not been updated and nothing in it should be relied on without checking.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR FAMILY

- Verify at the source before acting, including anything in this guide.
- Check the reference section at the back for figures current to this edition, and note the date they were current.
- When a school's own policy differs from general practice, the school's policy governs.

REFERENCE

2026-2027 Figures

Every figure in this section changes. They are collected here, separate from the body of the guide, so that they can be checked in one place and updated once a year. Confirm anything you intend to rely on at its primary source before acting. Figures below reflect the most recent published information available at the time of this edition.

AVERAGE PUBLISHED COST OF ONE YEAR, 2025-26

INSTITUTION TYPE	TUITION, FEES, HOUSING, AND FOOD
Public four-year, in-state	$25,850
Public four-year, out-of-state	$45,780
Private nonprofit four-year	$60,920
Community college, tuition and fees	$4,150

Source: College Board, Trends in College Pricing and Student Aid, 2025. National averages. Published prices, not net prices. Most families pay less. Use each school's net price calculator for your own estimate.

HOW THE STUDENT AID INDEX FORMULA WEIGHS A FAMILY

COMPONENT	ASSESSED AT
Parent adjusted available income above the protection allowance	22% to 47%
Parent non-retirement assets above the protection allowance	Up to 5.64%
Student income above the protection allowance of $11,770	50%
Student assets	20%
Income and assets of grandparents and other non-parents	0%
Qualified retirement accounts and primary home equity	Not reported

Source: U.S. Department of Education, federal methodology for the 2026-27 award year. Protection allowances vary by household size, age, and marital status. The CSS Profile uses different rules and asks about several of the excluded categories.

KEY DATES

ITEM	TIMING
FAFSA opens	Historically October 1 for the following school year. Recent cycles have varied. Confirm the current date.
CSS Profile opens	Generally earlier in the autumn than the FAFSA. Individual school deadlines apply.
Early deadlines	Commonly November 1 or November 15.
Regular deadlines	Commonly January 1 through January 15.
Decision deadline	Commonly May 1.
Scholarship and priority deadlines	Set independently by each school and frequently earlier than the application deadline.

Dates vary by institution and by state and change annually. Build your student's calendar from each school's published dates.

FEDERAL GRANT PROGRAMS

PROGRAM	WHO IT IS FOR	ANNUAL MAXIMUM
Federal Pell Grant	Undergraduates with exceptional financial need	**$7,395**
Supplemental Educational Opportunity Grant	Undergraduates with the most need, administered by the school; not all participate	**$4,000**
TEACH Grant	Students preparing to teach in a high-need field, with a four-year service commitment	**$3,772**

Source: U.S. Department of Education, 2025-26 award year. Awards are subject to fund availability and eligibility requirements. For 2026-27, Pell eligibility is restricted for families with a Student Aid Index above $14,790. A two-parent household with two children generally qualifies for a full Pell Grant only at an income at or below roughly $54,600.

FEDERAL LOAN PROGRAMS

LOAN	RATE	2025-26 ANNUAL LIMIT	2026-27 ANNUAL LIMIT
Direct Subsidized	6.39%	$3,500 to $5,500 by year in school	$3,500 to $5,500 by year in school
Direct Unsubsidized, undergraduate	6.39%	$5,500 to $7,500, dependent students	$5,500 to $7,500, dependent students
Direct PLUS, parents	8.94%	Cost of attendance less other aid	$20,000, a new cap
Direct PLUS, graduate	8.94%	Cost of attendance less other aid	Phased out beginning July 1, 2026

Source: U.S. Department of Education. Rates apply to loans first disbursed between July 1, 2025 and June 30, 2026 and are reset annually. Federal loans also carry an origination fee deducted at disbursement. Borrowers with existing Direct PLUS loans may continue under prior rules for a limited period. These provisions changed recently and are worth reconfirming.

WHAT THE TWO AID APPLICATIONS ASK ABOUT

ITEM	FAFSA	CSS PROFILE
Taxable and untaxed income	Yes	Yes
Bank and investment accounts	Yes	Yes
529 accounts owned by a parent for the applicant	Yes	Yes
529 accounts owned by grandparents or other relatives	No	Yes
Equity in the primary residence	No	Yes
Retirement account balances	No	Yes
Family business or farm net worth	No	Yes
Non-custodial parent finances	No	Often

Illustrative rather than exhaustive, for the 2026-27 award year. CSS Profile requirements vary by institution. Confirm with each school.

EDUCATION TAX BENEFITS

BENEFIT	WHAT IT DOES	INCOME LIMITS
American Opportunity Tax Credit	Up to $2,500 per student per year, first four years of college	$90,000 single, $180,000 married filing jointly
Lifetime Learning Credit	Up to $2,000 per return per year, unlimited years	$90,000 single, $180,000 married filing jointly
Student loan interest deduction	Reduces taxable income by up to $2,500 per year	$100,000 single, $205,000 married filing jointly
State 529 deductions or credits	Varies widely; some states allow contributions to any plan, some only to the in-state plan, and some offer nothing	Varies by state

Source: Internal Revenue Service. The two federal credits cannot both be claimed for the same student in the same year, and tax-free withdrawals cannot be used for the same expenses claimed under a credit. Consult a tax professional.

EDUCATION SAVINGS ACCOUNT LIMITS

ITEM	AMOUNT
Annual gift tax exclusion, individual	**$19,000**
Annual gift tax exclusion, married couple	**$38,000**
Five-year forward election, individual	**$95,000**
Five-year forward election, married couple	**$190,000**
529 to Roth IRA rollover, lifetime maximum	**$35,000**
529 to Roth IRA rollover, annual maximum	**$7,500**
529 funds usable for K-12 expenses per year	**$20,000**
529 funds usable for education loan repayment, lifetime	**$10,000**

Sources: Internal Revenue Service and program administrators, 2026 figures. Rollovers to a Roth IRA carry additional conditions, including that the 529 account has been open at least fifteen years. State tax treatment varies. Consult a tax professional before acting on any of this.

> **A closing note on these figures.** If you are reading this guide more than a year after it was published, treat every number in this section as a starting point for verification rather than as fact. Section D of Part Seven lists the primary source for each category.

What to Do Now

One hundred pages is a lot to hold at once. Here is the short version, organized by where your student is today. Do these four things and you will be ahead of most families in the country.

EIGHTH AND NINTH GRADE

- Map the course sequence through twelfth grade, especially mathematics and world language.
- Calculate the scored income year. Take the fall your student will enroll and subtract two.
- Look at whose name is on each savings account.
- Let your student try three activities and expect to keep two.

TENTH GRADE

- Take a full timed practice SAT and ACT, then commit to whichever fits.
- Narrow to a general area of study. Not a career, not a major, an area.
- Run net price calculators for three to five schools while they can still shape the list.
- Review asset positioning while that window is still fully open.

ELEVENTH GRADE

- Build the list on both axes, admission likelihood and cost structure together.
- Ask two teachers for recommendation letters in the spring, before the fall crush.
- Look up the scholarship deadline separately from the application deadline at every school.
- Protect the summer. The list, the essay, and the activities record all belong in July.

TWELFTH GRADE

- File the FAFSA as soon as it opens, and read it twice on two different days.
- Decide your two borrowing ceilings before any offer arrives.
- Compare offers on gift aid only, using the worksheet in Part Seven.
- Ask for reconsideration if you have documented grounds. The worst outcome is a no.

If your student is already enrolled, the list is shorter still. File the aid forms again every year, know the exact renewal threshold on every scholarship, and check that the credit load actually leads to a degree in four years.

ABOUT

Strategy West College Planning

We are an advisor-led college planning firm working with families from eighth grade through enrollment. Our advisors and affiliated firms have guided more than 17,000 families through this process over three decades.

We built our practice around the idea in Chapter 2, which is that academic positioning, student development, and financial strategy are three dimensions of one decision rather than three separate projects. Most families work them separately, usually with different people, and usually starting the financial one two years too late. That gap is where the money and the options go.

Every family we work with works directly with a senior advisor. We do not guarantee outcomes, because nobody honestly can. What we do is make sure the right decisions get made at the right time, with the information a family needs to make them.

THE NEXT STEP

Tell us where your student is, and we will tell you what we see.

A consultation is a conversation, not a sales meeting. We will look at where your family actually stands across the three pillars, tell you which levers are still open to you, and give you a clear picture of what a structured plan would look like from here.

There is no cost and no obligation. And if we think your family is in good shape and does not need us, we will say so. We have done it before and we will keep doing it.

meetings-na2.hubspot.com/will-smethurst/swfcp-college-planning-guide

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